

Table of Contents

Moonsea Rising!	4
Playing the Game	4
A Story of Greatness!	4
It's a Weeks-Long Party!	4
The Feast of the Ascension!	5
"From Death, Life."	7
Moonsea Rising -20230730	11
Helpmoot	11
Return to Jambis	11
On to New Towne	12
Moonsea Rising -20230813	14
Cadmus is a Dick	14
Moonsea Rising-20230924	17
Aftermath	17
Moonsea Rising -20231008	18
"Malvolio"	18
Moonsea Rising -20231022	21
Hail, Hydra!	21
Through the Looking Glass	22
Moonsea Rising -20231105	23
A Fungus Among Us	23
Beyond the Violets	24
Moonsea Rising -20231119	26
When Are We?	26
Still Not Dead Yet	27
Moonsea Rising -20231216	29
Fouling The Ritual	29
Just the Facts	29
Moonsea Rising -20231230	31
Aboard the Vile Flame	31
Breaking the Bruleicos	31
Moonsea Rising -20240114	33
Mayhem at Brulehaven	33
Cellar Dwellers	34

Moonsea Rising -20240211.....	35
The Battle of the Scions	35
The Temple of Xul'Jarak	36
Moonsea Rising -20240224.....	38
Elsewhere	38
The Traveller	38
Moonsea Rising -20240310.....	42
The Sea Cave	42
The Sunken Horror	43
The Final Harken.....	43
Moonsea Rising -20240406.....	45
Dark Thoughts	45
Harken's Return.....	46
The Well	46
Moonsea Rising -20240421.....	48
Gotta Go Back in Time	48
How Bazaar	49
Moonsea Rising -20240505.....	51
Friday Night Magic	51
Give Me that Shiny Rare	52
Moonsea Rising -20240519.....	53
Building the Playset	53
Sun and Storm.....	53
Return to Xul'jarak	54
The Moon	54
The Wizard's House	55
Moonsea Rising -20240602.....	56
The Sun Still Rises	56
Paradise Regained	56
In the Ghetto	57
Moonsea Rising -20240615.....	59
Dinner at the Ironclaw's	59
Moonsea Rising -20240629.....	62
The Ironride's Maiden Voyage	62
Moonsea Rising -20240727.....	66
Moonsea Rising -20240810.....	69

The Harkening	69
Gnomolotion	69
Moonsea Rising - 20240825	72
Saviors of the Shadowbark.....	72
Hot Times, Summer in the City	72
You son of a bitch. I'm in!	73

Moonsea Rising!

Like all great empires, “progress” in the Moonsea Empire proceeds at the behest of a select few, the elite. Those select few, great men and women though they may be, are driven in turn by small things: whimsy, greed, fear, disease, love, or a perfectly timed and executed bit of violence.

This campaign is designed to give you a chance at rising to great heights, certainly high enough to join that select few who can change the fate of an empire. Don’t worry, we’ll get a chance to run our blades through fantastic beasts, detect secret doors, and, sure ... ok, yes, cast fireball.

Playing the Game

But...the deadliest game you will play is the game of politics. Indeed, the men and women who engage in political intrigue and tactics in the Moonsea Empire call it “Playing the Game.” Although some of the more ethical players argue that it is bad form to visit dire consequences on someone who is not “in the Game”, everyone agrees that once a person joins the Game, all bets are off.

You are about to join the Game. You will investigate (and maybe even help form) secret alliances, match wits with senators and diplomats, and play dirty pool against some of the most skilled spies in the Moonsea region.

To what end? Well, that’s for you to decide. Perhaps your group will avert a civil war or start one! You may work to curb the power of the military or promote the influence of the clergy (Praise be to the Sun and Storm!). Save an emperor, join a coup, install a puppet regime, or just get filthy rich off the chaos while pretending to do one or all of these things: Your choices are many.

No matter your goal, the order of the day is action, espionage, and intrigue. You are dashing elites who sip exquisite drinks in formal clothes one night, only to crawl through the mud and cut down enemies the next.

A Story of Greatness!

When the adventure starts, you will have little, if any, political power (although you can spend a feat at character creation to start as a member of one of the powerful noble families of Melvaunt). You may be minor nobles, merchants, clergy, or even commoners, but through your adventures, associations, and possibly the largesse of the gods, you may rise to become some of the most important figures in all the Moonsea Empire.

This campaign uses special custom backgrounds to help players craft characters more likely to take part in the kind of story we are telling. These custom backgrounds -Minor Noble, Moonsea Patriot, Senatorial Hopeful, and several others -are merely jumping off points for the collaboration to come. The story is ours to tell together!

It’s a Weeks-Long Party!

We will begin our shared story in the glittering capital city of Melvaunt, during the Festival of the Ascension. This weeks-long party celebrates the rise of the empire’s Founder, Edric Storm, to the

throne and, so the history books tell us, his apotheosis to the status of a demigod. Melvaunt is a city of extremes; despite being among the wealthiest in all Faerun, it hosts one of the

largest populations of destitute and homeless residents. While they share a city, each population leads very different lives, separated by wealth and tradition more than stone walls.

The Festival of the Ascension provides a motivation for characters to gather in Melvaunt, even if they must travel from the far-flung comers of Moonsea or beyond to do so. Minor nobles, ordinary citizens, and even peasants try to make the trip at least once in their lives to see the capital at its most convivial. Even citizens from Baldur's Gate, Memnon, Westgate, and Marsember make the long trip to Melvaunt to enjoy the fireworks, parades, feasts, and sporting events that fill the weeks leading up to the Ascension. Entertainers from across the Moonsea region journey to Melvaunt to capitalize upon the cheap food and generosity the festivities encourage.

Tourists and opportunists alike can find the same appeal in the spectacle of the Ascension, but the weeks are business as usual for the year-round flow of trade. Melvaunt's port sees an endless succession of trading ships arriving from and departing toward destinations all over Faerun. With so many important people all in the same place, this is a time when important treaties are signed, and trade deals negotiated against a background of wine, music, and raucous colour. And just as Melvaunt attracts politicians and strangers, it attracts schemers and criminals aiming to take advantage of both.

The Feast of the Ascension!

The weeks-long Festival of the Ascension climaxes in a grand ball, presided over by the Stormlord and held in the Asberyth, a massive complex that hosts both the Moonsea Senate and the world-famous Senatorial Archives. The Feast of the Ascension always features a Who's Who of Moonsea nobility and celebrity. The emperor gives a speech. The Senate takes a ceremonial vote to kick off the summer session. And one commoner gets chosen to be elevated to the status of minor nobility. Very exciting!

Adding to this year's excitement are rumours that the Moonsea senate will take up the vote during its next session on whether to repeal the three laws governing succession to the Storm Throne: The Race Law, The Sword Law, and the Storm Law. These laws — denying the throne to anyone who is non-human, a former High Stormreaver, or unrelated by blood to Edric I, respectively — each have their supporters and detractors.

Of course, the senate will not choose any of these highly controversial issues for the symbolic first vote of the session that takes place just before the Stormlord's speech. But the gala represents a prime opportunity for the support and opposition of the various laws to "whip" the vote; to push and cajole and, if necessary, coerce senators and their influencers to the desired outcome.

While some factions may favour the repeal of one or more of these laws, the Imperialists can be counted on to staunchly oppose any changes to the laws of succession. Indeed, Lord Storm has made it obvious to all that he sees the desire to overturn these laws as a direct attack on his crown. Some Imperialists fear that such a vote would be the first step towards an attempted coup. And with no heir apparent, the stakes couldn't be higher.

Regardless of which side of the issue a given citizen supports, nearly every Moonsea native is passionate about the vote, and waiting for the results with bated breath.

Wherever your character hails from, two things bind you to your fellow adventurers: a keen interest in the fate of the Moonsea Empire and a woman named Lady Martella Longtooth. Whatever brought you to Melvaunt — your own political ambitions, a contest victory, a

diplomatic mission, or something else — also earned you the attention of this young schemer looking for fresh talent for her own growing web of intrigue.

In exchange for your service, she offers coin, new clothes, and invitations to one of the most prestigious social events of the year: the Feast of the Ascension. Anyone in Moonsea needing a favour, an ear to bend, or a patron can find one during this annual event, as senators and nobles alike gather for hours of food, wine, and music, as well as for official senate business to be conducted before the Stormlord arrives to formally exalt one lucky citizen to nobility. No matter your feelings on the busywork the Lady Longtooth has in mind, these invitations represent rare access to high society and networking opportunities that can change the courses of lives.

“From Death, Life.”

Lathander paints a rosy face on death, but dying is hard. Blood, pain, and terror are all that you know until you fall into oblivion.

If you are lucky, you awaken in the presence of my beloved Morning Lord. All is well again. If you are unlucky, you live through your suffering. You awaken still in the world, consumed by the horror of your circumstances. I was unlucky. I survived. The trauma of our encounter with the Hag will be with me till the end of my life.

I pushed myself up off the ground, out of the dirt and webs. I heard conversation close by, so I stood and followed the sounds. Newborn kittens had more strength. My injuries were life threatening. The Hag had been unkind and saved my life, but only by just enough that I still breathed. My armour was scraped and torn and covered in blood. The buckles were broken, and parts were missing.

I saw Harken first, then the Hag, and then the Ogre Spider. There was no sign of Etienne.

“Where's Etienne?”

The Hag's answer was the stuff of nightmares. I was struck dumb as she described Etienne's heroic self-sacrifice with evil cackling glee. I will miss our Champion keenly. In remembrance of him, I will end this Hag, her sister, and all their wicked progeny even if it takes me the rest of my days.

I watched and listened. Harken had debased himself to save my life. Disgust and shame were all over his face, at least for those who knew him well. He was negotiating with the Hag to save the Telus Barony. While negotiation was Harken's forte, the Hag wanted what she wanted, which was Harken.

Good! More of the bitch's progeny to kill. In Lathander's own words, before there is life, there is death.

I refused to be included in the Hag's machinations. I had not asked to be saved and would have gone to Lathander most willingly. Robbed of the hard-earned opportunity to gaze on the face of my beloved Morning Lord, I stood apart from Harken and the Hag while they concluded business.

My skin crawled with disgust on Harken's behalf. Although the Hag was presenting as a beautiful and desirable woman, I knew what was underneath. So did Harken. In this guise, the Hag was like an apple. Delicious on the outside but rotting away on the inside from her blackened core.

Then they both disappeared. The Hag must have been eager to consummate her deal with Harken. Bile was rising in my throat at the thought of him having to go to bed with that horror. Lathander's teachings on sexual union had nothing to do with coercion or control. The Hag had perverted a joyous and life-affirming act into just another form of selfish aggrandisement.

I was alone in the web-covered ruins of Jambis, except for giant spiders and one traitorous wretch whose days were numbered. I knew that if I saw our erstwhile guide, I would kill him outright. Best for him if he stayed hidden, or better yet, ran for his life. I presented a fearsome visage. Covered in blood. Armour destroyed. My murderous disposition driven by rage and grief was surely plain on my face. If he saw me, I hoped he would have the good sense to flee, and fast. I still had a working crossbow.

The handful of healing prayers I had left to me drew the warmth of Lathander's touch into my body. I was barely strong enough to make the journey on foot back to the Telus Estate. I set off to the south of Jambis hoping the guard captain we met earlier would lend me a horse. I was in no fit state to walk all the way back to Mooton where Harken, Etienne, and I had stabled our horses.

As I dragged one foot in front of the other towards the Telus Estate, I prayed to Lathander again. Would He recognise Etienne's heroism and ultimate sacrifice? Provide a good word on Etienne's behalf to the Source of his Champion abilities? I wanted Etienne's spirit to be hearty and hale in the celestial hall of his chosen God. He deserved that reward given the unspeakable horror of his death.

Praying with my whole heart while listening out for the thudding rush and clacking jaws of giant spiders was difficult, but possible. I had plenty of motivation. When I finished my prayer of intercession on Etienne's behalf, I scanned the terrain for crossbow targets. None came into view before I reached the Telus Estate, not even our traitorous guide.

Baron Telus' loyal captain was concerned for me and my missing companions. His compassion was heartening so I told him the sparest narrative of Etienne's death and Harken's disappearance. Even that nearly broke me.

I warned the captain that if Baron Telus contravened the rules of hospitality again, then the Baron would revert to his cursed form. If the Baron did not learn to curb his arrogance, I would ensure no further support from outside the Telus Barony. Not after we were betrayed to the Hag by the guide the captain assigned us.

The captain started speaking again. I held up my hand.

"No excuses! All I want is a horse. Far too small a recompense for Lord Betony and our Champion. A horse, and I will be gone from here." He had the good sense to listen.

I had forgotten Telus Barony horses were preyed upon by spiders of all sizes. There was also little in the way of food and care for them. The surviving mare the captain gave me was in a worse state than I was. However, we were both eager to leave the Telus Barony behind us. The mare and I compromised on a slow canter broken by bouts of walking so we could regain breath.

In Mooton I paid the gawping stableboys two gold pieces each to take diligent care of the mare, and of Harken and Etienne's horses. The mare needed extra oats and carrots to fatten her up. I warned the boys I would be back for my other horses in a few days. If they did not look healthy and well cared for, the boys would feel the wrath of the Morning Lord on their heads.

To where though? Baroness Adella Voight's prior invitation came to mind. I would have to take the road east to Voighton, then southwest to the Voight Estate. A long ride, but if I had understood the conversation between Harken and the Hag correctly, and yes, I know her name now, I just refuse to say it, then I only had a bare handful of days to organise our defences.

I hoped Baroness Voight would adhere to the rules of hospitality, regardless of my state of dress. I needed a safe place in which to recover, and my home at the Betony Estate was too far away. I would never make it that far in my present condition. Critical information I had gained listening to Harken's negotiations with the Hag must be passed on to Baroness Voight, and to **Nikolai, Baron Steele**. I could not risk a longer journey without first alerting our allies of the Hag and her intentions.

My arrival at Baroness Voight's demesne was heralded by a rider from her nearest checkpoint. He rode out at speed ahead of me on the orders of the unit's leader. I was weaving about in the saddle by the time I reached the checkpoint and had to be helped off my horse. The checkpoint guards were generous with water, food, and bandages. Lathander, bless them all.

I continued to Baroness Voight's main household with an escort of two more riders from the checkpoint. My story of giant man-eating spiders and malicious Hags must have given them cause to request additional soldiers in person. Either that, or they were detailed to help me if I fell off my horse. To my great relief, Baroness Voight welcomed me straight into her infirmary and the tender care of her primary healer. I only consented after making sure my horse was well taken care of.

Baroness Voight's keen curiosity warred with her genuine concern for my wellbeing, winning my complete trust. I asked her most humbly to send an urgent invitation to Baron Steele to join us, as I confessed, I did not have the strength of mind to tell my story twice over again.

In the gap between sending a messenger and receiving Nikolai, Baroness Voight insisted I rest. I tried, I really did, but every time I closed my eyes, I felt the Oger Spider's fangs stabbing into me. In the end, the healer gave me something to drink that pulled me past nightmares and into ... well, I was unaware, but the potion worked wonders.

On awaking, I found myself in the company of three of Baroness Voight's personal staff intent on making me presentable. These women had me bathed, dressed in borrowed finery, hair pinned up, lips glossed, and cheeks pinkened with military precision. The great pity was they could do nothing about the haunted look in my eyes, my drawn face, and my shattered demeanour. I shooed them out, then knelt in the middle of the expansive guest room.

Lathander, help me. I cannot do this alone. Will Harken ever come back to us? If he does, will he still be as he was, or will he be a slave to the Hag? Could I still trust him if he returned? These and so many other questions filled my mind. What to do, what to do?

One of the many reasons I love Lathander is because He never disappoints. All you must do is ask Him. I looked across the room at the lovely carved wood writing desk, at the elegant paper and envelopes with Baroness Voight's crested stamped on them, at the tall quill and jewelled glass ink bottle. Thank you, my beloved Morning Lord. Thank you with all my heart.

I sat at the writing desk and set out a sheet of paper, took up the quill, and dipped it in the ink. I had just finished putting quill to paper when Baroness Voight swept through the door.

"Baron Steele has arrived."

As I followed Baroness Voight through the central hallway and into the receiving room, I saw through the main doors that Nikolai had not travelled alone. His retinue of heavily armed soldiers were dismounting in the courtyard. One was holding Nikolai's horse as Nikolai ran up the courtyard steps two at a time. I was grateful he had the good sense not to ride all the way from his estates alone. Perhaps Baroness Voight's urgent invitation relayed what the advance rider had told her yesterday.

It does a woman's ego no end of damage to see the object of her affection stare at her in horror. I took in Nikolai's shocked glance as he entered the room where Baroness Voight and I were standing.

"Lady Beitris, what in the name of all the Gods happened to you?" Nikolai shifted from foot to foot, like he wanted to do something but thought he did not have permission. Curious.

Baroness Voight motioned for us to sit in the armchairs around the fireplace. "Please."

Nikolai and I took opposite armchairs while Baroness Voight took the one between us.

I drew a deep breath, calmed my racing heart, and began at the beginning. I was uninterrupted all the way to "and so here we are."

Stunned silence. Then the questions started. I was overwhelmed even though I did my best to answer them all. I held up my hand and they both stopped talking.

"I have every reason to believe the Hag means you harm, Nikolai."

I ignored Baroness Voight's raised eyebrows at my use of Nikolai's first name only.

"Deal with the vase of flowers as you would a mortal enemy. Hide it, destroy it, or do not let it into your home. The Hag is a shape changer. Be careful of new acquaintances. Perhaps even be wary of old acquaintances."

I stood up and stepped closer to Nikolai's armchair. He stood up and met me halfway, as a gentleman should. We were barely a foot apart. Baroness Voight watched us over steeped fingers.

I held out my hand to Nikolai, the envelope between my thumb and fingers.

"I have devised a clever passphrase so that you might recognise me, the real me, as opposed to a Hag who has changed shape to look like me. I believe I can say this passphrase with far more conviction than she ever could. I invite you to provide an answering passphrase of your own choosing, Nikolai, so that I might not be similarly deceived by a shape changed Hag. Your passphrase does not have to be any reflection of mine, just whatever you are comfortable to say to me."

Nikolai took the envelope from my hand. As he pulled it open and took out the folded sheet of paper, the keenest regret I had when I lay dying passed out from my heart and dissipated into the warm air around us. I watched his face as he read what I had written on the paper.

"I love you, Nikolai Steele."

Moonsea Rising -20230730

Helpmoot

As Beitris gives Baron Steele her message, he seems taken off guard. His skin darkens slightly, and he tells her, "I shall... use the same passphrase." Taevyn asks his lord, "and will you be telling us the passphrase my lord?" The Baron sputters momentarily. "Boy, how would that be wise? We are trying to ensure that a shape-changing hag is not able to deceive one or the other. Exposing such a secret risks that endeavour."

As Taevyn sulks at the rebuke, a servant enters and announces the return of Lord Harken Betany, who follows him into the room, walking normally. He greets the nobles he knows, Voight, Steele, and Marsk, as well as noting their retinue. The Baron has brought Taevyn and Lennox with him, and Lirael is seated by the Baroness. He asks Beitris how much of Agatha's doing has been discussed. She has discussed most of their interactions in detail, while staying away from the details of their compatriot's passing.

Lord Betany speaks more about what they found in Jambis, and that they had to make several deals, including a vase to give to Baron Steele. Beitris's counsel is that he smashes it, having received it from them. Lirael inspects the magic and suggests that perhaps that isn't the wisest action. It seems to be soul bonded to someone, and she surmises from Beitris's aside that it is likely Baron Steele. She advises that the Baron guard it well but prevent it from coming to harm if he is able; neither to further interact with it if he is able.

Baron Steele designates Taevyn and Lennox to act as his proxy in the handling of Agatha; Lirael asks to come along as well. She offers that the hags might be a symptom, rather than a cause of the ills befalling the county. Something is moving in the natural world. Beitris mentions the vampire in Mooton, the ghast in Stavys, and that Agatha mentioned Goldpebble. Lirael recalls a fable of a gold dragon by that name, who cut off and cursed a noble's lands for stealing his hoard. She notes that this is just a story, but perhaps Agatha's foe feels this fable represents them in some way and has taken the name as a symbol. Harken recalls that Goldpebble was there as on the bridge over the Gold Canyon will never be repaired.

Baron Steele seems deeply interested in the possibility of a dragon to slay, though Lirael cautions him that not all dragons are evil despoilers of the countryside, and that he might not wish to hunt a good dragon to make his name.

Return to Jambis

Lady Marsk is still quite upset about the spiders in the Webwood, though she wants to see what kind of humanitarian aid is needed in Jambis. Lirael tells her the spiders of the woods were little enough trouble before they were cursed, and that the silk harvest was a major export for the region. As they approach Jambis, Harken and Beitris both begin to look grim and shaky, as though they'd rather not return to the town. Taevyn and Lennox offer to go into town, and Lirael offers to accompany them, offering sympathies to Harken and Beitris for what they've gone through.

As they ride in, a white-bearded barrel-chested man leaps down from one of the buildings being cleansed of webs and greets them. Taevyn asks if he's Clarence, which he is, and asks if he remembers anything, including offending a cleric of Lathander. He is confused and tries to accommodate Taevyn's questions but is having difficulty following along. He seems to believe it is still two years ago.

Lirael tells them that the spiders were ensorcelled, and that if they are unable to remember, then it is probably for the best. The crowd starts to panic, but she calms them down, and tells them that they are safe now, and should count the forgetting a good thing. That they are there to help assess the damage and see what aid the county can provide them. They tell them they plan to ride on to the Baron's estate and see what in what state he finds himself.

Back on the road, Beitris apologizes to Harken for her refusal to go into Jambis and asks if he himself is alright. Harken reassures her, unconvincingly, and they sit in awkward silence with their memories. When the three return to them, Beitris asks about the villagers, and Taevyn says they're seriously messed up, and remember nothing. He asks if the big one is the one who, "ate her friend?" Beitris stiffens at this but agrees that he is. Taevyn tells her he doesn't think he remembers, and Lirael adds that she is sure he does not.

Moving on to the estate, Frater Mosley meets them, effusive in his gratitude for lifting the curse. Beitris rather sharply reminds him that the curse is not lifted, only in abeyance pending the completion of their agreements with Agatha. Taevyn remarks that he, "must be as stupid as Clarence," which takes the Frater aback. Noting Taevyn's livery and bearing, he treats him with the respect due his position as Steele's ward.

Beitris asks him about clearing out the stinging vermin in the manor, and he assures her they have been dealt with. Glancing towards the greenhouse, it appears that they have just boarded everything up, which she notices with distaste. There are also boards laid across the pit trap, which the Frater quickly crosses to announce their arrival to the Baron. She attempts to get the guards to tell her if the creatures have been dealt with, and they are reluctant to do so, or to contravene what Frater Mosley has said. Mosley returns and tells them the Baron will meet with them in his chambers. They follow the Frater into the main hall of the manor.

Baron Telus is an older, but not an old man. He is grossly obese but seems to be sane and vaguely believes that he knows some of the party. He identifies himself as Aaroch Telus. The Frater identifies Harken and Beitris, but he only identifies Taevyn, Lennox, and Lirael by their trappings. Lirael tells him the Silverweave's speak well of his Barony's silks.

The man is oleaginous, explicitly ensuring they feel welcomed by his hospitality. He is deeply concerned with getting the manpower to restore his Barony's industry; woodworkers, farmers, and silkwrights. It is clear acting hospitable is difficult for him, and he would very much like to hit Taevyn for his manner. Lirael reminds him to have the silks from the cleanup boiled as they go, as the bounty is likely to be able to fund much of the restoration. He sees the wisdom of this immediately and agrees to investigate it.

Back outside, Beitris asks after Jim Smythe, the brother of someone who had asked after their kin in Jambis. He tells her he was their escort out of the Barony. She growls that he was the one who had betrayed them to the hags. She passes on his sister's message, in case he returns, but warns that he should avoid Beitris at all costs.

On to New Towne

New Towne seems not to have been caught up in the Webwood's curse. Beitris tells her New Towne was the demesne of Agatha's sister, and she doesn't know what she was doing, but her touch seems to have been lighter. Lirael casts detect magic and, while there is no enchantment on New Towne now, there are echoes of powerful fey magic. Beitris hails a shepherd driving his sheep across the bridge, and he tells her Mayor Vort can be found in the tavern, where she resolves to go to see what the state of the town is. Harken asks Lirael

about the fey fleeing the region, and what might be causing it. She tells him that they fey are tied to their domains, and a threat so great to the wyld magic deeply troubling.

As they enter the tavern, they find only two people at a table: Cavidius Vort and Cadmus Callahan. Lirael stiffens on seeing Cadmus, as Vort invites them to sit, and tells them they have much to discuss. Cadmus accuses them directly of treason, and suggest they surrender, rather than be killed. As several men rise from behind the bar, and the door bars behind them, Taevyn draws his rapier.

Moonsea Rising -20230813

Cadmus is a Dick

The people behind the bar appear to be a barkeep, and elderly beggar, a crying peasant woman, a commoner, and the waitress. None of them seem to be happy, possibly because each has a noose around their neck, run up to the rafters, and they seem to be standing on tiptoes, as well as being gagged.

Cadmus asks if they'd like to surrender and admit to what he's been told about them overthrowing the Count. Harken says they should be able to do this without involving the smallfolk. Cadmus snaps his fingers, and Harken disappears. Lirael detects the echoes of fey magic having been cast beforehand. Cadmus asks if any of them wish to deny the allegations.

Lirael and Taevyn tell him he's clearly wrong. He takes a moment to denigrate both, and turns to Beitris, to accuse her more directly. She starts talking past him, slagging him off to Lennox. He claims her beloved horse is being roasted for food, but she doesn't take the bait.

The bearded man beside Cadmus backs up his claims as he represents the law in this moment. Taevyn begins towards the bar to cut down the bound captives, but Cadmus and his friend warn him off. Cadmus represents them as tried and convicted traitors, which Taevyn is unmoved by. Cadmus directs the mage to deal with the party.

The mage begins casting. Beitris casts shield and gives Lennox heroism. The wizard creates a wall of air to slowly start pushing the prisoners off the bar. Lirael slings tendrils of sap at Cadmus but fails at hitting him. He throws a dagger at Beitris, but misses, and ducks behind a table. Taevyn flourishes his rapier, drawing the mage's attention, and dives across the bar towards him, knocking one of the women causing her to put more weight on the rope. He tumbles behind the mage, and slams him with the guard on his rapier, hitting him heavily. Lennox sprints towards Cadmus, hitting him with his axe. Beitris summons a mace of spiritual energy which strikes at Cadmus, missing him across the table, and raises her shield again.

The mage flings a sphere of fire at Taevyn, who dives aside. He grabs the bartenders to hide behind. Lirael squats down, and a black bear rises through her. She thunders across the room to the left in the bar. Whipping a pair of spiked manacles off his belt, Cadmus snaps them on Lennox's wrists, the spikes biting into his flesh.

Taevyn whips out his dagger and cuts the barkeep's hands free. He crams the dagger into his hands, yelling to him to cut himself down. Lennox struggles against the magical manacles, trying to break free. He slashes Cadmus with his axe, roaring in frustration. Beitris directs the spiritual weapon at Cadmus, but he dodges it. She advances on him, raising her shield again. The mage laughs at Taevyn's attempts to save the barkeep, and pushes the flaming sphere at him again, though he dodges. He runs back along the bar and pulls the nearest captive off the bar.

Lirael climbs atop the bar, and with two quick swipes cut down the woman who passed out and the man the mage pulled back. Cadmus slashes twice at Lennox, missing on the second cut, as the big man mocks him. Taevyn dives and dances through the commoners on the floor, getting behind the mage. In the distance, a horse screams in agony. He runs the mage through with his rapier, and the wall of wind immediately ceases. Dropping her illusory form,

an unknown hag is revealed. She is devoid of color, with taut skin and electricity crackles in her white hair.

Roaring loudly, Lennox struggles against his manacles, but cannot break their grip. Beitris slashes out with divine lance, running through Cadmus, and directs the mace to follow him, but misses. Lirael steps closer to the remaining commoners, cutting one down, and then biting at the hag, but missing on the latter.

Cadmus taunts Beitris, claiming familiarity with her "arcane tricks", and proceeds to continue to try and murder the bound Lennox. The point of his rapier appears through the big man's shoulder, and drawing back he stabs him through the throat. As the big man falls to the ground, he strides toward Lady Beitris. Taevyn leaps up on the bar, and cuts down the waitress, securing the last of the commoners. He whips the dagger at the hag, cutting her deeply. In the corner, Lennox's wounds weep as the man lies still.

Beitris tries to cast a spell against Cadmus' mind, but he shrugs it off, chuckling. She swings her mace, but the blow glances off her. Lirael bites the hag, and swipes at her twice, connecting with a claw as well. The hag summons a thunderhead within the tavern, and blasts Lirael, singeing her fur badly. Cadmus then stabs Beitris and retrieves another set of manacles from his pack. Taevyn drops behind the bar, tumbling through the air, and slashing at the hag. He yells at the commoners on the ground to flee the storm, which they all start doing. As Lirael dives out of the way of the storm, the hag directs a bolt at Taevyn, hitting him badly. Turning to Lirael, the space around her shifts and merges as her form is compressed down into that of a bunny. Turning its tail, the rabbit flees from the building, hiding beneath the level of the deck outside.

Cadmus continues to taunt Beitris, suggesting he might go for some rabbit stew. Instead, he stabs Beitris repeatedly, the horrible beak on his weapon slashing her deeply. Tapping his feet, Taevyn grabs the hag in a whirling dance, spinning her and himself away from the stop. Flinging her aside, he stabs her repeatedly with his rapier, leaving her near death. Beitris heals herself, then directs a beam of holy energy into Lennox, as the man awakes with a jolt.

The hag fires a jet of water at Taevyn, slamming the young man backwards into the storm, where a bolt of lightning strikes him, blasting him down to the floor. Gathering herself outside, Lirael turns back into her bear form, crouched by the deck. Meanwhile, Cadmus manages to slap the manacles on Beitris' wrists. Behind him, Lennox manages to snap the manacles on his wrists, and stands up.

Beitris steps back from Cadmus, raising her shield. The hag flees across the room, and throws a lightning bolt at Lennox, which he turns away from. Suddenly, the blood loss gets to her, and she drops to the floor.

Roaring, Lirael smashes through the window, snapping and clawing at Cadmus, who dances away from her strikes. He ripostes with his rapier, and she drops hard to the floor. He moves to slash at Beitris, but her shield holds. Lennox shouts at Cadmus, "die, little man!" Rushing forward, he slashes at him with his axe, but misses. Beitris struggles against her bonds but fails to free herself. She restores her shield, and shoves him, hard, off the table. As he falls, Lennox strikes him a glancing blow with his axe. Shaken, Cadmus springs to his feet, and slashes Lennox twice, dropping the big man again.

Beitris manages to wrench free of her manacles, and blasts Lennox with healing sunlight. As the hag's magic ebbs, Harken Betony reappears by the door of the room. Taking in the scene, he quickly strides behind Cadmus, slashing at him twice with his rapier.

Cadmus looks around. The fight, having gone decidedly to his disadvantage, he ducks away, and turns and flees the tavern. Lennox follows, slashing him as he tries to mount his horse. Beitris focuses, and a coruscating rainbow of colors blasts throughout the room, healing everyone's slights. Harken strides out of the room, drawing his bow and sends an arrow straight into Cadmus' back as he mounts. Lirael stands up and jumps back through the window leveling a blast of searing light at Cadmus which misses him.

Cadmus finishes mounting the horse, and, as he whips it on, Lennox brings his axe around in a flat arc, decapitating him in one fell swoop. The horse flees as the man in black falls to the dirt of the road, in two almost simultaneous thumps.

Following the others outside, Beitris finds the remains of her beloved horse slain by the hitching post.

The barkeep and others crowd around the party, thanking them for saving them, wondering if they were still under sentence of death. Lirael tells them she doubts Cadmus' charges are known beyond those alive. She counsels that they do something with Cadmus' remains, lest this only get worse from here.

Moonsea Rising-20230924

Aftermath

As Taevyn catches his breath, Harken curses under his. "Damn it. Almost had her." The party re-convenes on the floor of the warehouse. Lirael asks if they think they might catch her, as they'll never have a better opportunity to finish her off. Everyone else -- her back is turned -- catches that a work desk, more of a door with legs than a true desk, is sitting in the corner, groaning under a substantial weight of paperwork.

Striding over, Harken starts rifling through the papers, pulling out several ledger entries, as well as some personal correspondence between Tomag, Fyndellion, and Autumn Silverweave about this operation-- though in several of the documents they used the pseudonym "Silverware". Clearly in league with the Militarists and Maxilar Brule, the TrueSilk™ and ColdSilver® are clearly intended for a military purpose.

The TrueSilk™ doesn't appear to be magical at all. Lirael is impressed, though her distaste with House Silverweave's methods is evident. Harken and Beitris are hell-bent on burning down the warehouse, which seems like it will disrupt this scheme, since the ledgers don't show any shipments leaving.

The timeline suggests all of this was started by an order nearly a year ago, well before Edric III's death. The party begins wondering if there are other locations in effect, but the numbers for this location alone are staggering. As they consider destroying millions of gold worth of TrueSilk™, Lennox wonders if there are rivals of House Silverweave that might have use of the product. Beitris knows that House Brightsail, maker of sails for House Elgata's navy, would love to get into the business of fashion.

As they pack up to go, Lirael circles the building locating two more magical trees, both of which contain magical runes, one to the west, one to the southeast, and the original large tree to the north. She posits that the northern one is likely for carts for the outgoing shipments, while the other two might go to Jambis and New Towne.

Beitris remembers a scrap of paper she found in the warehouse. It had three sets of initials, as well as a word. Those are: NT - bingo, MV - fruit tree, PB - logarithm. They guess that those might be New Towne, Melvaunt, and the Palace of Birdsong. Lirael remarks that burning this lot is going to ruin at least one noble house, as well as possibly marring the remaining teleporters.

They resolve to try the southeastern teleporter, on the premise that it's likely to be New Towne and using the password "bingo" has them standing in the hag's supposed house in New Towne. They searched the house quickly, finding no recent evidence of Bronwyn's return. They debate whether to try and return to the warehouse before the fire consumes the other circles.

They try a couple of the command words, but nothing happens. Lirael posits that the rug might interfere with the sending. Rolling up the carpet, they manage to teleport back to the tree. While the invisible warehouse is merrily blazing, they hurry around to the other smaller tree. the word "logarithm" they are transported to a luxurious vaulted room, with an intricate inlaid rune of stained glass. A dome of stars overhead, an alchemy set in the corner, and a pulsating glowing Bronwyn slumped in a chair. At the door stands Count Bartleby. He says, "ah, you're here. Sooner than expected. 'Malvolio'." Everyone's stomach lurches.

Moonsea Rising -20231008

"Malvolio"

The party finds themselves in a small room. Contained is a statue of a robed figure with a religious symbol around his neck and a sword in his hands. No one recognizes the symbol or the statue, except Beitris who believes it might be a statue of Cyric. The room is 20'x20' with no obvious doors. The sword is not statuary, but rather a real sword with an inscription in an unknown language. The magic pervades the room, with the most powerful being evocation magic. Lennox inspects the sword closely, as Lirael warns him that the magic she detects is likely involved in the creation of energies.

As they search the room, she notices a seam in the wall behind her. Alerting the others that there seems to be a door in the wall, she moves to the corner. As Harken starts fiddling with the door trying to open it, she raises her magical shield. Beitris follows suit, as the others brace for whatever might happen. It silently opens on a 10'x10' hallway that seems to end in the back of another secret door. Lennox moves up to listen at the door. He hears something rhythmic, almost mechanical.

Beitris, meanwhile, looks closer at the inscriptions on the blade. It appears to be written in abyssal, and the best she can do is "out of many circles". She tells Lirael what she's interpreted, and the elf is much disturbed. "I shouldn't like to touch it but leaving it behind us seems very dangerous." Harken, meanwhile, joins Lennox, but can't hear anything interesting beyond the walls. He warns them they're about to open the door. Taevyn moves up behind them, as Lirael and Beitris hang back against the walls. Harken's paranoia is buzzing, and he triple checks his work on the door before opening. Lennox jumps through as the door opens into...

A greased slope, towards several rotating blades! He manages to keep his feet, but that doesn't prevent him sliding down the slope. As everyone looks on in horror, they note that the blades are rotating slowly, but appear to have chopped up several goblins in the prior weeks or months, who lie strewn about. The blades aren't moving terribly fast, but there are a lot of them, and they look very sharp. Lennox looks at them and moves around the poles, slowly, assessing. Harken, on the other hand, is looking for controls, and finds a series of buttons with letters associated with them, though their function isn't obvious. Taevyn, much amused, tumbles through the room, avoiding the blades, and somersaulting out into the next room. He takes a small bow.

Lennox attempts to avoid the blades while chopping at the poles, missing a few swings, but chopping gamely into the poles. They are very hard, and he does little damage. He leaps back out the way they came. Lirael has an idea and stepping into the room and slipping down the slope. From the ground, she casts tanglefoot, wrapping around the nearest pole and stopping the blades from turning. She calls to the others "this won't hold for long, but I should be able to get us across."

Beitris and Harken slide down, and he navigates the two poles Lirael hasn't immobilized. He leaps up the far side, joining Taevyn on the small ledge adjoining the back of another secret door. Taevyn inspects the door, and then pushes it slightly open. A shout in a guttural but unknown language causes him to immediately slam the door closed, as several arrows thud into it. He looks for ways to possibly secure the door, but finding little he draws his rapier. Holding onto the door, he resists as a bugbear attempts to wrench the door back open but doesn't succeed.

Lennox, seeing all this from across the room, moves back to the statue of Cyric and draws the sword from its hands. It seems magnificent, and he springs back into the chopping floor, as Lirael stands up and stops the next pole from moving. Beitris moves by that pole, and darts around the last one, trying to get up the slope, but slips, getting nicked by the blades. Pulling out her hatchet to use as a climbing axe, she manages to lodge it in the slope, keeping herself in position.

Harken searches in vain for any sign of controls, but nothing leaps out to him. He also draws his rapier and helps Taevyn guard the door. Taevyn calls through the door, "we have a cleric here, and you don't want to be on her bad side!" A murmur runs through the monsters on the other side of the door. On the other side, something repeatedly slams into door. Taevyn opens it, and a goblin goes flying by and down into the pit. Two other goblins are sitting nearby rubbing their heads. Harken slashes at the goblin as it passes, and hitting the blades is the final straw for the smaller creature, who sticks on the blades, dead. The door begins smoking, and Taevyn nervously suggests others come help.

Bellowing at Taevyn to open the door, Lennox charges forward brandishing the sword of the Mad God. He knocks down a goblin on the way, and slashing the nearest goblin with the sword, it screams, and its eyes turn an inky purple as its life-force is drained by the accursed sword. The other goblins who were waiting for the door begin stabbing at Lennox with their heinous weapons.

Stepping forward to the next pole she'd stopped, Lirael sends a bolt of searing light into the nearest bugbear, burning him badly. Leaning on her hatchet, Beitris hauls herself to flat ground, and leans back ready to help Lirael. Harken slashes at the bugbear and flings a large stone from floor with a telekinetic cantrip into him, smashing him back against the wall, as Taevyn comes in with coup de grace, running the bugbear through. The other goblins immediately surrender, seeing the charnel house they've run into in the party.

As Lennox goes to sheathe the weapon, he finds it perfectly pristine and unblemished, with no sign of goblin blood. Beitris and Lirael are pulled up into the room, where the surviving goblins are on their knees in a religious fervour, pointing and prostrating themselves before the sword Lennox is holding. None of them speak goblin, but Lirael tries halfling, which some of them are passable in. They tell them they are waiting for the one who summoned them to this place, and she shall come for them soon. They don't know the way out, but they do know there are dangerous spore around, that are susceptible to fire. They leave the goblins behind and find a room with a large bonfire separating many mushrooms which exude a greenish haze into the air.

Taevyn excitedly asks Lirael if she has any fire spells to clear the spores, but she has nothing particularly of use to this scenario. Taking a flaming chair leg from the bonfire, she steps past it and examines the mushrooms. She finds that the construction on the other side of the bonfire is fine, good enough to be in a castle, but the brackish water running under the bridge seems to be fostering the growth of the mushrooms. They appear to be the kind of dangerous psychedelic fungi one finds in deep swamps. The bridge appears to be newer construction, not fitting with the rest of the construction. It appears that with torches they might keep enough spore away to breathe comfortably, but excessive exposure to the spores would be bad for them.

Taevyn wonders if they should try the door on the other the goblin latrine before risking the spore. He and Lennox slide past the foulness, gagging quietly at the stench. A wooden plaque, partially crumbled away, has some map of the area, with part of a blazon reading "are here." Further down the hallway, the map suggests, are several cells and other

hallways. The top right corner of the map has the common characters "eep," which he believes might well be "Keep." Beitris notes that the most famous keep in the region would have been Zhentil Keep, before Edric I destroyed the Zhentarim and renamed it. The Zhents were also followers of Cyric, which isn't a great convergence. Lirael wonders if maybe they're beneath Stormreaver Keep and goes to check the "swamp" running through the cave. The roof above it is dirt, with roots poking through, so they cannot be that far underground.

Harken, having been quietly musing to himself, thinks that maybe the "eep" comes from "Deep," of which there are a number. Combined with the brackishness of the water, he thinks they might be coastal. Given recent connections with Mulmaster, he wonders if maybe they might be under Ironfang or the The Blade's Deep in that region.

Looking down the hallway, it looks as though it is sliced from a building transported below ground, much as the break by the marsh. As Lennox passes Taevyn, he moves towards the Cyric-sword, but Lennox keeps it out of his reach. Beitris is watching Taevyn closely, as this behaviour is worrying her.

Harken is still wracking his brain for potential candidates for their present location. He recalls that the city of Phlan was transported to the Nine Hells several centuries back, as well as the great magics used during the defeat of the Zhentarim by Edric I.

At the end of the hallway is a "room," dug out of the dirt where the hallway ends. A broken coffin lies in the room, with the skeleton that occupied it strewn about. The room looks to have been dug out by claws rather than tools. The coffin appears to have been part of the process of digging out the room. Lirael thinks it was a huge lizard of some kind. Lirael thinks she might be able to dig out, using her insect form. As they're discussing options. Harken isn't sure, but he might be able to hear some earth rumblings to the west. Taevyn wanders down the hallway, and finds more water, with the roof of the dugout area coming down to the surface of the water.

Beneath the water, he hears a roaring sound, as several heads poke up out of the water, and watch him retreat down the cavern towards the rest of the party.

Moonsea Rising -20231022

Hail, Hydra!

As the horrible five-headed thing rises from the water and begins to slowly lumber towards the party, Lennox lowers his head and charges. His new sword glimmers darkly in the cave light as he lashes out at the beast, slashing it once. Taevyn dances around the thing, but its mass spans the hallway, he slashes at it, and raises his guard. Harkin fires his bow, striking the monster soundly, as Beitris summons her mystical mace. Lirael attempts to remember anything she can about hydrae but comes up blank.

Staring at Harken, the hydra launches multiple attacks at Lennox, managing to chomp him heavily, knocking him to the ground. Taevyn grabs Lennox body, and turns to flee, as the creature lashes out at him, felling him instantly. Harken takes one look at the creature, and he and Beitris flee to the underground complex, with Lirael behind them. As it slowly follows them down the corridors, they fire magics at it. Lirael attempts to charm it. This is unsuccessful, so moving back towards the fire, she calls to the others to lure it into the spores.

Meanwhile, the hydra roars, its wounds healing before Harken and Beitris' eyes. However, it seems unwilling to follow them any further into the keep. Worryingly, it is screaming while staunchly refusing to advance. Harken moves back towards the fire, and when Lirael asks tells her it isn't advancing. She remarks that perhaps they can drive it off, and steps forward, lancing it with a ray of frost. While it hits the creature, the frozen scales quickly mend and look new. Frustrated, it begins to burrow beneath the earth of the stonework. As it seems fixated on the remaining party members, Beitris steps back out and closes the door, obscuring it from their view.

After a few minutes all sounds cease, and they believe the hydra has retreated. Beitris tells Harken that if he can reach Lennox and Taevyn, she should hopefully be able to heal them. He opts to use stealthiness to sneak back to where they last saw the others and see if they can be retrieved. Sneaking down the corridor invisible, he finds the hydra has brought the lads back to her nest, waiting on her young to hatch to their first meal.

Harken returns and they formulate a plan for Lirael to lead the hydra into the waters in a shark form, with a lighted balloon. When she reaches a point the hydra can see, it immediately moves to follow her. She is much faster than it and leads it under the overhang. On the other side, the water ends, and the cavern opens up again. The waters lead off to the right, but a set of spike and bro

ken boats block the mouth. She weaves through it, and off down the corridor. As the beast follows her, Beitris sneaks down to the Hydra nest and casts her healing on the two unconscious men, who both wake up groggily. Unfortunately, the healing magics also cause the hydra eggs to begin hatching. Lirael finds the river forks to the north and south. Further south, an alligator-like river lizard rests. Behind her, the hydra immediately turns towards the sound, and starts moving back the way she came.

Beitris, Lennox, and Taevyn immediately start moving back towards the "safe" stoneworks of the keep. Lirael swims back towards the hydra and bats the light bladder at it, but it is no longer interested in her. She rapidly swims down the southern branch, hoping to circle back. As she speeds down the waters, the gator follows her, but doesn't manage to catch up to her enough to attack.

Lennox attempts to rush by the hydra, but as he moves past it, it lashes out and fells the giant man once again. Taevyn moves to the nearby crate and attempts to hide from the mother hydra. Harken moves to retrieve Lennox, but the hydra snaps at him and he also drops.

Lirael rolls out of the water away from the gator, and drops her shark form, she runs down the hall back towards the others. Beitris moves forward and heals Harken from a distance. Gesturing frantically, she beckons him to drag Lennox back. He begins dragging him, while Taevyn continues to hide in the corner near the hydra's nest. Lirael comes sprinting up the corridor, and finds Harken, Beitris, and Lennox. She races up, and helps Harken continue dragging Lennox back.

Taevyn tumbles past the hydra, limping up the hallway. Lirael steps up to see the hydra still perilously close to him. Gritting her teeth, she fires a ray of frost at one of the whelps, which screams in pain. The hydra rushes down the corridor, and wraps her body around the whelps, protecting them. Beitris calls to Lirael asking if Taevyn is moving, and the elf says she thinks he might be clear now. She turns to Lennox and heals him, waking the large man up. The party moves painfully back down the hallway, closing the door behind them.

Harken and Beitris are both quite unhappy with Lennox and, to a lesser degree, Taevyn. Lirael is quietly unhappy with the whole ordeal. Lennox also notes that the sword he took from the statue is still lying on the ground in the hydra cave.

The party makes their way back to the goblin's hovel, and bed down for a rest. Lirael describes the remains of the cave system from what she's seen, as they make plans to continue east through the spores. They drive off the gator with spells and arrows, and it retreats north along the "river".

Crossing the bridge, they find the carpet of spores is riddled with mushrooms from small to large size. Beitris thinks she sees one of the mushrooms move, and Lirael hits it with a ray of cold. It shudders, but immediately moves to attack.

Through the Looking Glass

Harken pulls out of a flask of oil and begins preparing an incendiary device. Lirael tells them that,

while they're just mushrooms in many respects, it is not a good idea to let them touch you. Taevyn tumbles past the nearest fungus, and pierces it twice, destroying it. Lennox wields his axe, and Beitris casts divine lance, almost destroying the second one. Harken switches out his bomb-making for his rapier, and Lirael sends another ray of frost, at the badly injured mushroom. It whips a sticky tentacle at Lennox, capturing his left hand, and begins squeezing.

Taevyn slashes at it, trying to help free Lennox, who tears his arm free, and strikes with his axe, finally killing it.

As they start down the hallway, one of the largest bushes starts shaking down the middle of the hallway. As Taevyn moves to one side, a rotting tentacle lashes out at his leg. He dances away, stabbing at the tentacle, as several larger fungi rise from the ground.

Moonsea Rising -20231105

A Fungus Among Us

Beitris summons her spiritual weapons to attack the giant fungus. Lennox rushes forward, wielding his axe, and striking the nearest one twice. Taevyn flips behind it, slashing it with his rapier. Two of the smaller mushrooms move up, flailing ineffectually at Lennox. Lirael recognizes the large ones as fungal assassin vines --very dangerous if they succeed at ambushing people. She calls out, "use your torches, and don't let them grab you!" Lashing out with tanglefoot, she wraps the nearest assassin vine in sticky sap. The other one lashes out at Taevyn, striking him with a tentacle. The tangled one wraps Lennox in a constricting grasp.

Harken throws his oil flask between the two assassin vines, followed closely by his lit torch. As the oil catches, another assassin vine flows up out of the nearest bush, missing him. Beitris lashes out at the most injured vine with divine lance, burning it badly. Lennox swings at it, hacking the body of the thing to pieces, freeing himself from its grasp. Swinging wildly, he turns towards the smaller mushroom, smashing it twice.

Taevyn moves back towards the entry way, engaging the vine by Harken. Lennox continues to fight off the mushroom in front of him, as it's joined by its companion. Lirael sends a searing bolt of light into the nearest one, splashing it with magical fire, and then shields herself. Harken slashes out with his weapons poking small holes in it with his rapier, but not doing much damage. The vine lashes out at Taevyn, but he dances aside, crashing his rapier down into it, knocking it askew, and parrying its follow up attack.

Beitris directs the spiritual weapon to smash the nearest vine, then showers Lennox with a healing burst of light, closing his wounds. With a roar, the giant man lashes out with the axe three times, nearly disassembling the smaller mushroom. Taevyn dances past the giant vine, lashing out with his rapier and leaving shreds of fungus mouldering on the ground behind him. The fungi around Lennox reach out for him, but only one connects a little. Lirael lashes out with a ray of frost, dispatching the damaged mushrooms, and maintaining her shield.

Harken grabs his torch off the floor and tries to fling it at the fungi ineffectively hassling Lennox, but he short arms it, and it falls uselessly in the middle ground. The nearest mushroom turns on him, and rushes forward, spraying a face full of spores at him, nauseating him. Beitris blasts him with healing light and pushes at the remaining vine with her spiritual weapon. Lennox lashes out at the vine mass, tripping it somehow, then swinging his axe in an arc at it, smashing it into the floor. Taevyn flies over it in a cartwheel, dragging his rapier through it and reduces it to shreds on the floor again. Lirael sends the ray of frost at the mushroom at Lennox hitting it.

Harken continues to try and fight off the mushroom attacking him, as Beitris sends the spiritual weapon to help him. Lennox continues to hack at the mushroom still standing in front of him. Taevyn flies forward, kicking off the mushroom and coming down on it with his rapier, notching another kill. Whirling on the remaining mushroom, with a cool looking but difficult to describe move, carving a giant chunk out of it. Lirael fires another ray of frost, as Harken pokes at it with his rapier, trying to end the torment. It lashes out at him further, and his sickness worsens, as chills and shakes wrack his body. Beitris' spiritual weapons come down, finally killing the last of the mushrooms.

Harken drops to his knees, vomiting, as his skin takes on a purplish cast. Beitris rushes over praying under her breath. A lambent glow washes over Harken, and his skin returns his normal colour.

Beyond the Violets

Moving the sign down the hall, they read it as part of the map. "Level B3", with arrows for "torture" and "clerical". Taevyn and Lennox are both excited to go through the northern passage towards "torture." There are skeletons in mouldy armour, with arrows around as though they had been shot. The rot suggests they've been here possibly hundreds of years. Harken approaches cautiously, looking for traps. While he doesn't find any, he does find an arrow slit in the wall.

Taevyn and Lennox follow him and hear screaming coming from behind the second door. It sounds like a woman screaming, "stop, please stop!" Taevyn opens the door, revealing a young woman being accosted by a man with a hot poker. Lirael and Taevyn both move to assist, but Beitris beats them both to it, sending a divine lance into the back of the torturer. Taevyn leaps forward, attempting and failing to spin the assailant away from his target. He swings at the poker, attempting to disarm the man. He calls out, "there's another one!"

The two men are wearing what looks clearly like ceremonial robes. The second man points a ring bearing a skull over a black sunburst on it, and a wall of force slams into Taevyn. He drops his shoulder, skidding sideways across the room. He comes to rest over a rune on the floor, from which tendrils of necrotic energy flare out, gripping him and sapping his strength. Harken fires his bow, missing, and shouts at the visible cultist, attempting to intimidate him. Lennox races up, sweeping a kick at the torturer's feet, and missing his follow-up stroke with his axe.

Lirael strides into the room. For a moment, she's confused, as their garb looks like ancient Zhentish priests of Cyric. Clearly, that's madness, as the Zhents were broken over 200 years ago. She yells to the torturer that he ought to fight someone who can defend themselves. He laughs and plunges the poker into the woman's throat. "We'll get to you soon enough, sweet tits." He lashes out at Lennox and misses. From behind the arrow slot, a third man fires a crossbow at Lirael, striking her twice after quickly reloading.

Beitris casts a field of bane at the torturer, and he resists its effects for now. Taevyn tumbles back into the room, both hands braced on the rapier. Running the torturer through, he stands over the man's fresh corpse. Harken moves forward, menacing the other cultist with his bow, before shooting an arrow into him. Lennox sweeps the man's legs from under him, slamming his prone body with the axe. Lirael moves into the room, yelling that there's someone behind the arrow slit. She whips sappy vines at the other cultist, tangling his prone form. Behind her, a spear slashes out from the arrow slit, catching Beitris twice. She moves up, increasing the area of the bane, and shields herself.

Taevyn tumbles forward, awkwardly and unnecessarily, slashing at the cultist. He raises his ring and sends another wall force slamming into Taevyn, Lennox, and Lirael. They're all slammed back, and Lirael and Taevyn end up on the rune again. Harken telekinetically flings everything in the room at the remaining cultist in the room, smashing him with the torture implements in the room, and striking him down.

Lennox rushes up to Lirael and pulls her out of the runic circle. She immediately shields herself, gasping that there's still someone behind the arrow slit firing on them. Beitris grabs Taevyn, pulling him out, and touches Lirael, healing her a little.

On the other side of the room, they hear someone shout "now!" The door flies open, and arrows fly into the room. One strikes Taevyn, who immediately drops. The door immediately shuts and clicks as though it were locking. Harken draws his bow, aiming at the door. Lirael straightens whispers some arcane words and shifts into a massive beetle. She turns towards the door, ready to rush it. Beitris casts a massive heal, catching everyone in the room.

Someone yells, "now!" and the door opens. Lennox immediately steps through, attacking the man behind the door. He swipes at Lennox, then whistles as a creature that looks like a zombified baboon bounds forward towards Lennox. Harken shoots an arrow, hitting the cultist by the door. The baboon scratches Lennox and tries to grapple. Lirael skitters forward, slamming into the cultist by the doorway and pushing him back.

The Bowman fires on Lennox but misses him. The cultist at the door steadies himself and pulls a vial of liquid from his pocket and prepares to lob it. Back in the prior room, Taevyn climbs to his feet. He attempts to distract the cultist and moves into cover. Harken fires two arrows wildly, and shouts, "Cyril commands you to avert your eyes!" The one by the door inadvertently looks down before catching himself.

Lirael snaps her mandibles on the door cultist twice, and he screams in pain as they clamp painfully on him. Beitris heals Taevyn, who seems much less close to death. She extends the bane. The archer fires on Lennox and hurls the potion he was holding. The other cultist strikes at Lennox but misses him. Lennox slashes at him with the axe, hitting him three times in rapid succession. The monkey swipes at him, missing him as well.

Taevyn leaps into the room, rolling past the baboon and lashing out with his rapier. Missing, he whirls on the cultist, but the man dodges his strike. Harken focuses on the cultist and slams him with the rubble in the room, dropping him instantly. Lirael snaps at the baboon but misses him. Beitris steps into the centre of the room and attempts to disrupt the undead baboon. Holy light surrounds him, burning him badly.

The remaining cultist fires on Lennox, attempting to kill the big man, but in the melee, all three go wide. Lennox attacks the baboon, hitting it once with his axe, and it returns the favour, though it misses each time. Taevyn inexplicably backflips before running through the baboon. He dances and tumbles around the archer, teasing him up for his killing blow. Harken uses his telekinesis again, but the cultist dodges the detritus. Lirael follows Taevyn, chomping on the cultist.

Beitris continues to extend the bane ring, and casts a divine lance at the cultist, but misses. The archer, committed to taking someone with him, fires on Lennox hitting the giant again, but failing to kill him. Lennox shares this commitment with him, at least. He advances, swinging his axe, and catching him a solid blow. Harken rains them with trash and effluvia but doesn't damage the cultist.

As Beitris heals Lennox, the party cuts down the final cultist. Dropping back into her elven form, Lirael slumps against the wall, breathing heavily.

Moonsea Rising -20231119

When Are We?

The party gathers the cultists and looks through their belongs. Taevyn nimbly pockets the ring before the others can examine it, to pointed looks from Lennox and Beitris. Interestingly, this cultist also has several maps on him, but they look... odd. Lirael recognizes almost immediately that Hillsfar's map is only the old city, and the Melvaunt map is similarly out of date. The third, "Merrat", shows a county that looks much sparser than they have encountered, with names that are well out of date. There are numerous things missing, references to slavery, and myriad other anachronisms.

Taevyn and Lennox are deeply interested in the door behind the rune. Beitris and Lirael think fouling the rune should work, but it is etched into stone. Grimly, the two men set to work on the block with some of the torture implements, carefully working from the side to destabilize the rune's underpinnings. They eventually wear enough of the material away, and Taevyn strides --confidently or foolishly --across the broken rune, assuming that's sufficient. He turns out to be correct, and opening the door they find another similar hallway to the one they've left. To the north, there are several more ambulatory mushrooms, as well as the bend of the waterway. He creeps further along and finds a side branch with more fungus and another door. Lennox joins him, and the mushrooms turn towards the two of them and begin advancing.

One moves up and strikes Lennox, spraying him with spores, and whacking him with its tentacle. Lirael strides forward and uses tanglefoot to slow it down. Taevyn flips past it, lashing out with his rapier and cutting huge swaths of its fibre away. Lennox knocks it down, chopping away at it, as he sways slightly from the spore infection. Harken cuts it down with his telekinetic abilities, and Beitris spears the one next to it with a divine lance. The fungi continue to strike at Lennox.

Lirael focuses her magic, and her arm turns into a gouging claw, stretching and lengthening to impossible dimensions, slashing at the mushroom by Taevyn, over 20' down the hallway. Taevyn flips past it, spearing it with his rapier, and shredding it on his follow-through. Harken and Beitris target the next mushroom, bringing it down with their powers.

The last mushroom continues to strike at Lennox, hitting him once. Lirael moves across the opening from it, firing a ray of frost, which rips into it as Taevyn whips by it, chopping it cleanly in thirds.

Taevyn and Lennox move to the door, opening and quickly slamming it. Lirael prepares a ghost sound to hopefully confuse their tremor sense behind them. Lennox opens the door, and two of the fungi immediately attack him. He slashes with his axe, knocking one down, and catching the one next to it on his two slashes, and destroying the one he knocks over. Lirael releases the ghost sound, but the effect seems to be limited.

Taevyn whirls about, desperately trying to look cool before slashing out at the mushrooms. After a couple of tries, he finds his groove and skewers the nearest one badly. Beitris and Lirael finish it off with light and frost respectively. Back in the room, one of the mushrooms confusedly moves to attack where the ghost sound is coming from.

Lennox and Harken manage to put down the last one that isn't distracted. The group moves to quickly dispatch it before it can move to attack. They find three beds with dead cultists, though the corpses appear to be hundreds of years old. The party decides to camp out in

this room, though Lirael is confused as to why there'd be both living cultists and long-dead ones in the same complex, as well as a variety of dangerous creatures.

Still Not Dead Yet

The party decamps after everyone is rested. Exiting the room, they don't find anything lying in wait for them, despite Lirael's misgivings. Moving to the north, Taevyn sees more cultists around the corner. As they debate their next course of action, more fungi rise to attack them. Low chanting starts around the corner. Lirael tanglefoots the nearest mushroom, backing away from the corridor intersection. Taevyn fires two shots with his crossbow at the mushrooms, following Lirael backwards.

Fighting and backing up, the party hears a klaxon sounds down the corridor and the chanting redoubles. The mushrooms continue advancing, as the strange chanting increases in volume and fervour. A small stone bounces around the corner. Taevyn and Lennox dive for cover, but Beitris is caught in a massive blast of source, as are the two mushrooms. Lirael and Taevyn kill the struggling mushrooms, while maintaining their angle on the corridor.

Beitris prays, and a circular bubble of light forms around her and most of the party. One of the cultists steps up and fires a crossbow at Lennox, hitting him. He calls to the others, "what are you doing? Attack him!" Another cultist steps up and slashes him with a greasy kukri. The third cultist, wearing silver-trimmed robes of high quality, casts a spell attacking Lennox's mind. The dome of light crackles and pulses, and Lennox seems unaffected. Lirael shouts at the caster, "your god is dead, you fool! Lay down your arms!" The priest merely laughs. She launches a bolt of searing fire at the cultist in front of Lennox, burning the man extravagantly.

Beitris summons her spiritual mace, swinging at the leader. One of the cultists says to him, "they're going to interrupt the ceremony!" He laughs and tells the man, "It's too late." The cultist bows his head, and charges Harken, slashing him with his kukri. The priest sends black tendrils out to lash Lennox, Taevyn, and Beitris. Lennox rushes forward and smashes the leader with his axe. The cultist next to him moves to flank him but cannot land a hit.

Darting forward, Lirael weaves between the combatants towards a opening behind the scrum. Muttering the words of her spell, she shifts and grows. Standing up and roaring, she turns into a tyrannosaurus, taking up half the hallway. Dancing forward, Taevyn spins and whirls, executing his dance moves. He stabs the caster, ripping his form through the man, and cutting him badly. Beitris strikes him with her spiritual weapon, and heals herself, cutting off the bleeding from the tentacle attack. The cultist between Liraelosaurus and Harken strikes at him, but misses. The leader reaches out and touches Lennox's forehead, and the big man fades and disappears. Liraelosaurus, thinks Lennox has been disintegrated. Lennox, however, simply sees the world in limed in bright purple light as the sounds fade around him.

Harken slashes at the cultist between him and Liraelosaurus with his rapier, then smashes out with his telekinesis, but the cultist fends off the blows. In the fading world in which Lennox finds himself, he swings his axe at the priest. A perfect cut, but it slashes directly through the man as though he were not there. All he can hear is the sound of the chanting, which continually grows in volume. The cultist that was attacking Lennox turns on Taevyn. His first shot misses so badly that Taevyn tags him with a riposte. After missing a second time, he raises his hand and blows some kind of flaky skin dust at Taevyn, but the boy dances away. Liraelosaurus bites the priest twice, savaging the man, and swings her tail at him, but he manages to deflect that blow.

Taevyn spins and dances, stabbing the priest twice, the final blow passing through the man's throat as he falls to the ground. The cultist between Harken and Liraelosaurus turns tail and flees down the corridor towards the chanting. Harken steps towards the remaining cultist, running him through badly with his rapier. The cultist is bleeding heavily and off-balance after the blows, and he follows him companion fleeing down the hallway. Roaring, Liraelosaurus stomps after him, biting him as she passes, heading towards the source of the chanting. Taevyn sprints behind her, killing the cultist as he passes, and moves to flank the other cultist. He flees into the room the chanting is coming from.

As Harken and Beitris struggle to catch up with the party, the insubstantial shade of Lennox drifts into the room, where the light looks least purple. He sees an archway that leads into a room that looks normal and non-purple. A priest with a sacrificial dagger stands over a woman on an altar. A couple of cultists on the other side of the portal notice him and point in his direction. Liraelosaurus follows, unbeknownst to her, and sees the arch glowing purple, the cultist on his knees before summoning his healing fungus. She stamps through the portal, appearing in the scene Lennox saw. The cultists are shocked by her appearance, and the chanting falters. The high priest tells them, "No, fools, we're too close!" As he raises his dagger over the sacrifice, she chomps him biting heavily into his flesh.

Taevyn comes along behind and asks the cultist where Lirael went. He says, "back." Taevyn cuts the man down and looks around bewildered. Harken and Beitris follow him. Harken asks where Lirael went, and Taevyn tells him he doesn't know. Taking the same guess Lirael did, he steps through the portal onto the scene of carnage she's attempting to create. He draws his dagger and throws it at the priest, though he manages to dodge.

Meanwhile, Lennox decides it's time to charge through the portal, which he does. Passing through the portal, he does appear to be back in reality, and his swing at the high priest glances off the man but doesn't pass through him. Taevyn and Beitris, trailing behind follow the others through the portal.

Moonsea Rising -20231216

Fouling The Ritual

As the priest shouts at the participants to continue the ritual, they begin fleeing Lirael through the single door. She notes three other portals, like the one she came through, though they're not fleeing into them. They're yelling to the priest to allow the guards to handle it and calling for the Merovingians. Beitris, Lirael, and Lennox recognize the name of the elite Zhentarim guard, long gone from this world.

Lennox hacks into the fleeing cultists. Beitris tries to return through the portal but strikes the wall behind it. Lirael grabs the priest in her jaws and shakes him, then chomps him down whole. Beitris steps through another portal, as Harken attempts some kind of distraction, and follows her, with the others following as well.

On the other side, they find themselves in a small cell. After banging on the door a couple of times, Lirael releases her form, and everyone catches their breath. Harken manages to quickly pick the lock, as footsteps sound in the hallway beyond it. The female says, "be mindful of Galina. She and I are not always amicable." The male replies lightly, asking why he shouldn't have had this info prior. He agrees to mind his tongue, addressing the woman as "Strikeleader." Harken and Beitris both recognize the title as one from the Selunite sect known as the Silver Swords. Beitris wonders aloud if it might be Jessica Talianos, wife of the first Emperor Edric. Harken steps out to introduce himself, all smiles.

The tall, dark-haired woman is wearing silver-trimmed armour, and looks quite weary and battle-worn. The man with her seems jaunty by comparison, and leans back with his arms crossed and a chuckle, asking Harken, "oh, where did you come from?" Jessica asks if they are "Brulicos," and Beitris identifies them as Lathandrites. The woman demands to know what Lathandrites are doing in the Temple of the Whip. She addresses the man as "Edric", much to the shock of the party.

Jessica and Edric lead them further into the temple. They pass multiple novitiates of Loviatar, dressed in burlap, shoeless, dirty, and covered in small wounds. They are escorted into a large chamber, where a young girl with white hair and pale skin seems to oversee the Loviatarians.

Jessica begins negotiating with Galina --presumably a Shadowbanks --about the recovery of the missing noble scions. Beitris is cagey about being interrogated under magical compulsion in front of Edric and Jessica. She recognizes Lirael's lineage, and wonders at their appearance with the Silver Sword. Lirael tells her it's a long story, but likely has little bearing on her business at hand. The Whip Maiden is amenable and has them escorted to more guest-oriented chambers.

Just the Facts

The party takes a few minutes to discuss the implications of being in the past, and possible interrogation by the high priestess. Beitris is worried about altering the past, though Harken and Lirael point out that they may have already altered the past in the past, and to not alter it would be dangerous. Lirael ponders the priestess' recognition of her. Her grandmother spoke of Edric's liberation of Hillsfar, but not often of what the family was up to during the horrors.

They are eventually escorted back into the High Priestess' presence, and she casts a zone of truth on all of them. She seems initially convinced they are Zhentarim, but they assure her, under the zone, that they are not.

Lennox, Taevyn, and Harken immediately start spilling their guts, discussing the future, and their travel from it. Galina seems very interested in the future of her church and her house and begins doing calculations on how this information might be useful to her. Under Galina's urging, Beitris lays out the history of the War of the Scions. She also asks Lirael about the Liberation of Hillsfar and Battle of Zhentil Keep. Lirael asks her how she knows her family, and Galina tells her they are powerful, but likely still enslaved under Malthir in Hillsfar.

Galina seems convinced that defeating Brule is in her house and church's best interest. She offers the party their lives, if they will be bound to help Edric defeat the orcish invasion. The shackled pair is brought back in and freed. Exiting a secret tunnel, they find themselves in the docks of a much smaller Melvaunt than Harken and Beitris remember. There is smoke and clamour in the distance, and it's clear that there's unrest in the city. Edric rushes them to a rowboat, and they cast off and return to his ship ahead of any blockade.

Edric scampers up the rigging to the deck, with Taevyn following awkwardly behind. Jessica and Beitris are hauled aboard in baskets, weighted down as they are with armour. Edric has them made comfortable aboard the Vile Flame and tells them they'll meet with Laronen in the morning. Torbick escorts them belowdecks, where they are brought to a section of bunks they can use for the duration.

Moonsea Rising -20231230

Aboard the Vile Flame

The party is escorted into a room where Edric and a Red Wizard are having tea. Edric excitedly introduces them to Laronen. The wizard sighs and puts down his tea, as a feeling of powerful magics washes across the party. Edric flashes briefly with a purple aura, easy to miss. Edric begins cold reading the party members. Lirael claims to be a Stardancer, from beyond Mulmaster, but Edric buys it not a little.

Laronen sarcastically suggests they raid Brulehaven and rescue the scions of the major houses. Edric jumps on the idea and is ready to go. Laronen begins providing them some of the intel Edric has gathered, including a purple-robed wizard named Montravious and a vicious pet dog who guards the man himself.

Harken, Edric, Laronen, and Beitris begin pitching around ideas for a distraction, from riots to arson to exposing gay lovers or creating the illusion of the Brule scion about in the city. Lirael suggests that perhaps Lady Talianos might take several Silverswords and demand entry to Brulehaven to search for the scions. Admitted or not, this has the potential to be a sufficient distraction for the infiltration. Laronen is a big fan of this surgical idea, and Edric thinks it better they do not burn Melvaunt to the ground.

They concoct a plan for Jessica to take some pirates disguised as Silverswords and call on multiple houses before Brulehaven. Edric suggests Norster and Marsk would be amenable to assisting here.

Breaking the Bruleicos

As Jessica and the "Silverswords" announce their presence at the front gate, Edric and the party come to the northwest corner. There's a small building that acts as a sally port. Lirael approaches the single guard as the rest move off the deal with Jessica, and asks him about the house, claiming to be touring historic architecture, and casting charm. The guard resists and tells Lirael to move on. As she moves off to the south, the party tries to stealthily circle around him to the north, but he spots them immediately. Taevyn says they're with Lirael for the tour, but the guard nervously reaches for his whistle.

Harken reaches out the man's mind and yells, "watch out for that knife behind your back!" The guard twitches slightly, half turning his head as Taevyn races in, slapping the whistle to the ground with his rapier. Lennox rushes forward, delivering two massive overhand blows with his axe, leaving the guard bloody and near death. Lirael races up, swinging her staff at the man to attempt to knock him out, catching him sharply across the temple. The man falls to the ground, unconscious. Taevyn quickly turns out his pockets and finds a ring of keys, as Lirael listens at the door to the building. A gruff male voice is apparently singing inside the building.

With nowhere to stash the body, Lirael suggests they tell the man in the building that the Silver-swords attacked the guard. Opening the door, they find a second guard enjoying a meal, out of armour. He immediately panics and starts backing away, as Harken tries to convince him someone else attacked Bobby (the guard). He doesn't buy it and makes to leave as Lennox and Taevyn rush after him.

Lennox vaults the table and gets there first, delivering a crushing blow from the side of the axe, knocking the man aside. Taevyn dances across the tabletops, flipping behind the

unarmed man with his rapier in hand. He whips the thin sword across the man and reaches out to grab him. Harken strides up to the man and tells him, "Stay down if you want to live." The guard is terrified and curls up on the floor. Taevyn asks him where the prisoners are, including Argens Brule. The guard is convinced that he's been kidnapped with the other scions. Taevyn is sceptical, and he asks where such a captive would be held, if they were here. The guard is certain the Bruleicos would never do such a thing. As Harken is binding him, he loses consciousness.

Lirael is concerned that this is going poorly. Lennox and Taevyn are surprised she thinks so, and Harken classes their infiltration so far as "undetected and unharmed". They move to the only door, which opens into the main courtyard of the compound. Harken peeks out the door, and notes that the described building with the cells, a squat, unlovely building, lies directly to the east. As the only visible guard moves off on his circuit, the party rushes to the cellblock. They find the door locked, but one of the keys on Taevyn's ring unlocks it. Looking at the rest of them, he shrugs meaningfully to the door. He pushes it open, and they find a cell with three beds and no prisoners. They pile in and close the door, as the guard wanders past again outside.

Once he passes, they open the inside door, and move into the interior hallway. They find a cage, which Taevyn unlocks. It contains an unknown prisoner who identifies himself as Tarrien Ilgata. He claims, rather convincingly, that he knows where the scions are, and can help them, as well as paying a 1000gp ransom if they release him. Beitris is sceptical and tells Taevyn they'll return for him if his info is good.

Waiting for the guard to pass, they move to the next block. A loud clanking of chains and grunting noises come from behind the door. Lirael thinks it might be a large humanoid type, potentially even a giant. She counsels against unlocking the door, as Lennox and Taevyn try and decide if they should do so. The next door sounds like it has a small crowd of men dining in a mess behind it, and the door beyond that as what sounds like two guards debating if there really is an army of orcs poised to attack the city. Running out of time on the guard patrol, Taevyn unlocks the door, and they rush in.

Moonsea Rising -20240114

Mayhem at Brulehaven

As the party tumbles into the room, the Bruleicos immediately draw their weapons. One immediately runs for reinforcements while the other steps up and attacks Taevyn, hitting him with his polearm. Taevyn sweeps into the room, spinning the guard away from the door so the others can get in. Harken steps back and fires two arrows into the guard. Lennox sprints into the room, swinging his axe. Beitris shields herself and summons her divine weapon, hammering the guard.

Looking around, Lirael decides that it's likely the guard will discover them before they can secure the room. Summoning her magics, her body shifts and swells into an enormous many-pointed buck. Sprinting swiftly towards the corner of the guard's patrol, she spies the flummoxed man, who stops in his tracks.

In the room, the guard attempts to flee, as Taevyn and Lennox hack at his back. He dives behind some boxes and starts making mechanical noises. The other guard hacks at Lennox twice with his falchion, critically wounding the large man. A third guard draws a massive sword from a weapons rack, and the fourth man, in wizardly robes, casts a ray of frost at Lennox, missing him, and moves to cover along the wall.

Taevyn dances past the standing guard and rips into him with his rapier, goring the man. He dances away from him and moves to cover the other man by the wall. Harken, meanwhile, races into the room and attempts to push the stack of barrels down on the man hunkering behind them. The man yells out, and a falling clattering sound indicates the barrels, and the man are falling down a stair to a lower level. He lies, groaning, on the floor below.

The guard Taevyn is standing next to slashes him with the falchion, but botches his follow-up attacks, allowing Taevyn the opening he needs to knock the weapon from the man's hand. Lennox swings his axe at the guard he's near, hitting him and knocking him to the ground. Lennox strikes him again, and the man drops his weapon, raising his bloodied hands in surrender.

The guard watches the deer suspiciously, as Lirael charges, goring him with her antlers. He slashes wildly at her but misses in three successive strikes. The guard with the crossbow pops up, hitting Lennox, reloading, and shooting again. The wizard casts a flaming sphere at Taevyn, who dodges away from it. He levels the dark ring at the crossbowman, and a blast of force knocks him back ten feet, dropping the crossbow in the process. Whirl, Taevyn slashes the guard, slaying the man immediately with a delicate thrust of his rapier. Harken continues to push barrels down on the guard whose fallen into the cellar. He's knocked back down the stairs, cursing under the blow. Harken leaps down on the prone man, slashing him with his rapier.

The guard who's surrendered tries to convince the crossbowman that it's time to surrender. He doesn't want to die. The crossbowman calls him a pussy, as Lennox charges him and smashes him with the axe. As he winds up for a second strike, the Bruleico catches the haft of his axe. Looking into Lennox eyes he whispers, "a worthy foe."

Beitris moves into the room, looking around. She redirects her spiritual weapon to the crossbowman, striking him. Outside, Lirael steps back and swings her antlers at the guard, trading misses. The remaining fighting guards attack Harken and Lennox, refusing to stop.

The wizard chases Taevyn around with the flaming sphere, though the young man nimbly evades it. He races to the main door, fumbling with the lock.

Taevyn dances after him but gets tangled in the man's flowing robes. Picking himself up, he dances around the man, slashing at him with the rapier. The attacks feel oddly resisted, but still hit him. Taevyn tells him to surrender, and he immediately does, having no stock in dying. In the basement, Harken manages to execute the guard he's been harassing.

Lennox continues to hack at the crossbowman, who doesn't seem interested in surrender, remaining defiant to his last breath. Beitris goes outside, trying to figure out where Lirael is. She redirects her spiritual weapon against the guard Lirael is fighting, smashing him with the ethereal mace. He seems to figure out some things and reaches for a whistle on his belt. Lirael swipes her antlers at it, but he manages to hang onto it, and turns to flee, blowing it.

Hearing the whistle in the distance, Taevyn demands the wizard tell him where the scions are being kept. He is confused, because they've been searching the city for the scions. Harken investigates the cellar and see that it does have a door that seems to lead to the south. He calls to Lennox to go help Lirael. Beitris gestures for her to come back, but Lirael sprints off to the south at her top speed.

As the party descends into the cellar, and guards mobilize throughout the compound, Lirael, playing the part of wildlife, bounds to the wall, and over it into the city. Dropping into her natural form, she nonchalantly makes her way back around the compound to their point of egress, hiding herself in the copse of trees in case Edric or the others need help escaping.

Cellar Dwellers

In the cellar, the rest of the party picks a locked door and proceeds deeper beneath the compound. Passing through one of the doors, they are sprayed by a fine green mist, which leaves them feeling nauseated and vomiting. Beitris' healers kit and her skill and knowledge help, however, and they're soon reasonably able again. They find a second locked door, which Taevyn manages to open with Harken's assistance. At the third door, they find another trap, which the two manage to disarm. Beyond, they find a dimly lit hallway with a bunch of barred cells. In one of the cells they find Joshua Brule, who is unaware he's beneath Brulehaven. He doesn't know where any of the other scions are.

Beitris puts him under a zone of truth to stop him and Taevyn from sniping at one another and tries to understand how he was taken. Josh is convinced that his father couldn't be involved, despite what the others tell him.

At the end of the hallway, a door opens, and a guard walks through. He seems oddly stiff, but then pitches forward, dead. Behind him, a grinning Edric Storm walks into the dungeon. He tells them he has a way out, and to get Josh back to the ship. The party follows him back up through the house, and a trail of dead bodies of servants, guards and many others. Eventually, the tunnels lead out through the chapel they saw on the way in, proximal, fortunately, to Lirael's hiding place. As she rejoins them, Edric saps Josh to exfiltrate him to the Flame.

Moonsea Rising -20240211

The Battle of the Scions

As the party looks down at the dig site, they notice some order in the chaos. Several guards around the entrance to the dig wall have a white hand mark on their faces. And, of particular interest, the guards all seem to be distracted by some kind of ritual bloodsport in a ring nearby. At the western gate to the site, a captain looms rather imposingly inside the gate. Ringing the site is a ten-foot palisade.

Harken suggests they open the gate the boars are kept in, perhaps causing some disarray in the orcish ranks as they try to recapture their food supply. Lennox, interestingly, recognizes the white claw marking as being specific the White Claw tribe. He knows they're fierce enemies of the Red Eye tribe.

As they're discussing options, a small detachment of orcs and goblins leave on patrol down the road. Lennox and Taevyn counsel for cutting them off. They try to cut them off, but the goblins' fine senses pick them ahead of time. One manages to flee back to the camp before the ambush, but the party doesn't think he saw specifically who the ambushers were. Harken starts trying to desecrate the corpse with Eye symbology and thinks they should continue to try and draw out the orcs. Lennox and Beitris think the orcs are equally or more likely to hole up in the camp and prepare for an attack. At Lennox' suggestion, Beitris attempts to create a false trail leading away from the ambush site.

They head back to the camp, which is abuzz with activity. The orcish commander is talking to the goblin, and barks something at the group of Bruleicos, who muster up near the gate. Several of the orcs join them, as well as one of the larger orcs, and they depart up the road. Assuming the timing is getting tight, based on the speed the patrol is leaving, they plan to further sow chaos.

Harken gives Taevyn his invisibility ring, and he clambers up and over the palisade. Heading towards the pen, the pigs scent him and start trying to locate him. He circles the pen cautiously, with the pigs tracking his movements as he goes. The orc commander notices and watches the gate. Taevyn draws a dagger, invisibly, throwing it away to try and distract the commander. He hears the sound, and, grumbling turns in that direction, calling out.

Taevyn opens the gate, and the pigs immediately exit the gate, following him, snorting and snuffling. Discarding the plan to set a fire, he sprints for the front gate, with the pigs in pursuit.

Lirael sees all this and assumes from their behaviour that pigs have scented Taevyn. Summoning her magics, she turns into a massive boar. Bellowing, she charges the orcs pursuing the pigs, who turn and follow her, enthralled with the Boar God in their midst. They'll fall on and slaughter the guards chasing them, and race into the camp, snorting and screaming. The orcs look around and see their dinner being led by a huge, frothing boar. They reach frantically for their weapons.

Taevyn looks twice, and heads for the braziers, unaware for the moment that Boarael is his elven companion. Lennox vaults the wall, axe glinting in the low light.

Taevyn flips the brazier as two of the massive orcs move to attack Boarael, both missing her in her battle form, as does one of the boworcs. She gores the nearest orc, hitting him with her tusks.

Lennox lands, smashing the nearby orc with his axe, killing him on the spot. Looking around, he races towards the next foe. Harken scrambles and awkwardly flops over the wall. Taevyn wall-kicks atop the embankment over the doorway, and lashes out with his rapier at the guard, killing him. He also charges the nearest other.

One of the White Claw orcs manages to slash Boarael with his scimitar, scoring her hide. Beitris manages to surmount the palisade slightly more gracefully than Harken before her.

What greets her is a scene of bedlam. Lennox and Taevyn grinning, covered in blood; Boarael at the head of a column of pigs and the orcs swarming around her. One of the orcs manages to cut her again, though her form is tough. Harken uses his psychic powers to fling a bunch of detritus at the nearest guard, knocking him from his perch and killing him. Taevyn slashes at the next guard along the wall, leaving him bleeding and near death.

Beitris summons her spiritual weapon, which lashes out at the White Claw attacking Boarael. She roars to the other boars to kill them all. Lashing out, she savagely gores the White Claw again as the boars rush from their grisly meal to the attack, savaging the remaining orcs. The White Claw lashes out at her, but his wounds are grievous, and he cannot connect.

Lennox swings his axe, flinging the guard through the air in smaller pieces. Harken blasts another with his psychic blast, killing it. Boarael and the pigs mop up the remaining orcs as Taevyn clears the walls.

As the boars feast, Lirael moves off towards the ruins entrance before dropping her disguise. Beitris heals her, as, despite the battle form, she's still frail. As the glow surrounds her, her wounds close and she thanks Beitris gratefully.

The Temple of Xul'Jarak

Descending into the earth, the party finds what the miners found --an ancient, buried temple. Scattered through the room are dead orcs. They have apparently been crushed to death. A teleportation circle sits in the south of the room, and four sarcophagi line the walls. Lennox has heard stories of such circles aging their users, and suggests they speed up their search. The corridors are unusual, narrowing significantly at intervals and with blind corners that harm lines of sight and travel. They find another room with a long table, with several dead White Claw orcs, who look like they have been frightened to death.

A book sits on the end of the table, and Lirael examines but does not touch it, casting detect magic. As the spell takes effect, the temperature in the room drops. The book emanates unholy magics, as several shadowy figures flow out of the walls.

One reaches out to touch Beitris as void energies flow through her. Her shadow appears to be yanked by the creature. She raises her holy symbol, and the room fills with sunlight. The shadows are wracked with the holy light, and the one that struck Beitris is dissipated into nothingness. The remaining shadows all turn towards her, slashing at her with their claws.

Lennox swings at the nearest one, cutting through it, though it seems immaterial. He swings at another, slashing it though it remains. Lirael fires a ray of frost at the shadow on Beitris, dissipating it as well. Harken flings a bunch of junk at the nearest one and retreats behind Beitris. Taevyn tumbles through the shadow, which scores him with his claw, chilling him. He screams out to the others not to touch the shadows. He pokes the rapier through it, seemingly without effect. He adopts his parry stance, looking worried.

The shadow near Lennox swipes him with its claw, weakening the large man. Some much worse creature with glowing eyes floats out through the walls, attacking Lennox and Lirael.

Lennox has the hand pass through him, as does Lirael, and both feel the life force being drained away. Beitris summons her god's power again, searing the undead and destroying the two shadows.

Lennox swings his axe, which passes through creature thrice, damaging it, but not killing it. Lirael shifts again, choosing the unicorn this time. She spears at the incorporeal spirit with her horn but misses due to the prior attacks.

Harken continues to mentally fling things at the spirits, to limited effect. Taevyn sways, attempting to use his normal parlour tricks on the undead, but they are generally unmoved by the silliness. The thing in the corner attacks Liraelicorn, hitting her twice and draining her again.

Beitris disrupts the nearly dead creature, causing it to dissolve. She moves forward, ready to help her companions. Lennox moves around the equine Liraelicorn, swinging his axe at the remaining creature. Liraelicorn tries to stick it with her horn but has no success. Harken continues his psychic assault, as Taevyn continues his ineffectual pokery. The wraith continues trying to drain the life out of Lennox. Beitris disrupts the last wraith, bringing it far closer to the eternal void, but it fights on.

Lennox weaking continues to swing his axe, showing defiance unto death. Liraelicorn finally spears it with her horn, the creature shrieking as the spirit magics wrack it. Taevyn slashes desperately, and the wraith finally succumbs to the onslaught.

Beitris casts restoration on Lennox and Lirael, removing the enervation from them. She also heals the party, though she, like Lirael is running low on energy for the day. Lirael attempts to take the book, but it and its plinth are both immovable. She notes that it's not a spell book, but rather a list of names. The most recent being General Sivelous Tuskclaw, and the others clearly being orcish or even more alien.

She notes that the book is clearly old, and the orcs worship some weird gods, and that the book is likely related to the undead in this temple. But without time to delve further, she recommends they find their quarry and flee. Taevyn looks to Beitris for direction on proceeding. She says they should at least try the door at the south of the room. Both Harken and Taevyn are quite certain the door isn't trapped, so Taevyn attempts to pick the locks. Despite feeling quite confident, he's unable to open the door.

Checking the east and west passages, they find levers just south of the room. Coordinating by shouts, Lennox and Taevyn pull the levers in both corridors. The locked door swings open, revealing a massive chamber.

On the southern is a huge dais, on which stands a glowing, faceless, tentacled humanoid, whose visage gives of a sense of nameless dread. A pile of dozens of dead orcs lies in the room. An ornately dressed military orc lies dead on a silver disc, and a human lies dead on a similar gold one. The human appears to be Argens Brule.

In alcoves along the walls, the five remaining scions are tied up and gagged. On the dais is a large chest, whose handle is a femur continually dripping some kind of fluid.

The humanoid speaks in their minds. "One shall ask; another shall pay."

Moonsea Rising -20240224

Elsewhere

Gozer: The Choice is made!

Dr. Peter Venkman: Whoa! Ho! Ho! Whoa-oh!

Gozer : The Traveller has come!

Dr. Peter Venkman: Nobody chose anything! [turns to Egon]

Dr. Peter Venkman: Did you choose anything?

Dr. Egon Spengler: No.

Dr. Peter Venkman: [to Winston] Did YOU?

Winston Zeddemore: My mind is totally blank.

Dr. Peter Venkman: I didn't choose anything...

[long pause, Peter, Egon and Winston all look at Ray]

Dr. Raymond Stantz: I couldn't help it. It just popped in there.

Dr. Peter Venkman: [angrily] What? WHAT "just popped in there?"

Dr. Raymond Stantz: I... I... I tried to think...

Dr. Egon Spengler: LOOK! [they all look over one side of the roof]

Dr. Raymond Stantz: No! It CAN'T be!

Dr. Peter Venkman: What is it?

Dr. Raymond Stantz: It CAN'T be!

Dr. Peter Venkman: What did you DO, Ray?

Winston Zeddemore: Oh, shit! [they all see a giant cubic white head topped with a sailor hat; Peter looks at Ray]

Dr. Raymond Stantz: [sombrely] It's the Stay Puft Marshmallow Man.

The Traveller

As the doors slam shut, separating Beiris from the others, the otherworldly figure speaks to the party's minds.

"One shall ask; another shall pay."

Coming from the walls in several places are creatures which seem to be made of the same substance of the walls itself. Suddenly, they all freeze in place, as Beiris appears in the room, standing on the golden etched circle opposite the one holding the corpse of Argens Brule.

She looks at the entity and says, "thank you." It looks at her and says, "ask, but be prepared to pay." She finds herself unable to will herself to leave the circle. Harken calls out

to her to hold her tongue, as she kneels to inspect the circle restraining her. While she doesn't recognize the words, she recognizes the script as thalassic.

Harken psychically messages the nearest scion asking about the effects of the disc. He is somewhat hysterical, and only begs for help. He attempts to contact several of the other scions, but they are scared, cryptic, and only sure that it's time to go. Taevyn rushes around the orc corpses to Beitris, attempting to remove her from the circle.

As he moves to touch her, a bolt of coruscating light lashes from the entity and burns his hand.

Lirael has been trying to discern what is going here. The entity looks like it might be related to an ancient, aquatic deity. The creatures in the walls appear to be wall wights, undead tomb guardians.

At Taevyn's request, she wends her way up to look at the circle. The thylassic is very ancient, and she only recognizes the concept of "fate" and "bundle" which she relays to Beitris with a caution.

Examining the altar, Taevyn and Lennox find a sacrificial dagger which has been somewhat recently used, as well as a ledger of some kind, indecipherable to them. The last name is General Siv Tuskclaw. The name at the top of the page is Fyndelion Silverweave.

As Taevyn starts trying to free the scions, Lennox goes to look at Argens Brule. He has three burns that look much like worse versions of the one Taevyn is now sporting.

Lirael tells Taevyn to ask Calman Larigan if he knows what Argens asked for. He panics and immediately tries to flee the room. Lirael tells him to remember his station and die, if he must, like a man. He pulls himself together and tells them Argens didn't ask for anything but was the sacrifice for the orcish general.

As Taevyn and Lennox finish freeing the scions, they start collecting themselves, but, other than Calman Larigan, don't seem quite as terrified of their current predicament.

Harken moves forward, his mind calculating his options. He asks the entity, "what is the point of these questions?" It responds, "a question is asked, and a promise is fulfilled."

A bolt of radiant light strikes Beitris, burning her badly. Benvolio Beregan pipes up that the general spent all the orcs on the floor asking questions. He says the general disappeared when the chest was summoned. Lennox wanders over to the chest and opens it. Inside are enough bones to make a large humanoid, floating in blood. Lennox is immediately sickened.

Based on Benvolio's remarks that if both discs are occupied, the asker is not the one who pays the price. Lennox thinks about this, and mounts the second the disc. As Lennox looks to be about to ask something, Beitris stops him, and suggests the brainstorm before asking questions. Lirael posits that not all requests are questions, and that asking for a boon or property could also be "asking". Benvolio suggests that she's on track.

After thinking about her family's history, Beitris turns to the entity and demands it, "let all living creatures in the temple return to the surface unharmed." A beam of light strikes Lennox, and they all hear the entity say, "granted." She can leave her circle, but Lennox cannot, and the door remains closed. As the party debates the best way out, Benvolio and Kara Caladra pipe up with more info. Benvolio tells them that the orc general didn't seem to be getting the results he wanted until he provided a blood sacrifice. Kara tells them that the general asked to be the most dangerous and feared thing in the Moonsea Region.

Taevyn notices that the passage behind the entity opens up into a narrow passageway. When he goes to investigate, he is struck by more radiant damage. He tells everyone there's a man down the passage, though he doesn't respond to calls. As Beitris and Harken try to formulate a strategy, she offers a prayer to Lathander. The entity turns red during this prayer, and the sound of clashing steel can be heard in the distance. Harken tells her to try that again and see if Lennox can step off his circle.

Taevyn, meanwhile, finds a secret passage that leads towards where he saw the man. He proceeds down, with Lirael following him, at a distance. Around the corner, they find a man in a hut made of mist. He dismisses his hut and speaks to them in a language they don't understand, but then casts comprehend languages.

The man tells Taevyn, in response to questioning, that the entity gave him eternal life, but he may not leave with it. She asks him if he's affiliated with the entity's god --he is not --and how long he's been there. He asks her if Fentia ever became a major power.

Lirael tells him Fentia vanished at least seven centuries prior. Mintiper Moonsilver, as he tells them his name is in response to Taevyn's question. After asking him more about the orcs, he tells them that the dagger "registers" the asker, and that the payment must have noble blood.

Lirael's heart sinks at that. "Lots," she thinks, "we'll have to draw lots." Mintiper offers them his treasure, a sharp spear, a chest full of silver, and a portable hole. She and Taevyn rejoin the others and share Mintiper's intelligence. Lirael tells them they should draw lots, but Harken rather uncharacteristically tells them that he does have noble blood, and he's probably the healthiest to still stand for it.

Taevyn tries to fetch the dagger from the altar, but the wall wights immediately move away from the wall. He drops it back down and looks to Lennox for more ideas. Lennox draws his own dagger, cuts his hand, and tosses the dagger to Taevyn. Taevyn smears the blood from Lennox' dagger to the one on the altar and uses it to inscribe Lennox' name in the book.

As Harken steps onto the other circle, the entity starts to glow, its tentacles waving. Mintiper chirps from the back room, "oh, this is gonna be good! Here we go!" Harken narrows his eyes at the ancient man's enthusiasm.

Speaking slowly, Lennox asks that, "all living creatures within this room, be allowed to walk out of this temple complex without harm, loss of stuff, and that it be now."

A beam of radiance bathes Harken in burning light. He drops to his knees, screaming, as the light burns him, though he is not killed. A door opens in the corner, revealing a black starfield with a suspicious lack of visible ground. The door through which they entered remains securely closed.

As the door starts to close, Beitris yells for everyone to run through the door. She and Taevyn bolt through, but find themselves, expectedly, in the depths of space. Taevyn manages to catch the doorframe, but Beitris isn't so lucky. Muttering, Lirael lashes out with a gouging claw, snagging the other woman, but cutting her substantially in the process.

Harken feels like they're secure enough, that they should take a long rest and try again healed up in the morning. Lirael casts detect magic on the chest, which resonates with every school of magic, and might well be the most dangerous, as the orc general wished to become. She resolves to attempt attunement as part of her daily preparation.

After her daily communion, Beitris heals herself and Harken. The entity seems unaffected by Lathandrite power in its vicinity.

Lirael's attunement to Tuskclaw's Chest brings a surge of power, and thoughts of dominance and control. However, Tuskclaw's soul will help her in exchange for some control. She believes she can return them to Melvaunt, at some cost. She asks Lennox and Taevyn to move the artifact into the middle of the room and gather everyone around it. They do, and Taevyn picks up Argens' corpse, saying he doesn't deserve to be left behind.

As Lirael prepares to transport them, Beitris tries to surreptitiously cast protection from evil. Lirael notices, as the protection spell sears her, and grasping the power of the chest, she immediately counters the spell.

Angrily, she rounds on Beitris, demanding an explanation. A defensive Beitris explains that it was protection against evil. Lirael rather snidely informs her that the chest is clearly evil, and if she could refrain while she's attempting to save them all, that would be best.

Darkly muttering, she turns back to the chest, her hands caressing its dark wood. Reality wavers, and they find themselves back in the warehouse in Melvaunt they were in with Edric.

Everyone notices that Lirael has fallen to her knees, her hand grasping the femur on the lid with a white-knuckled grip. Wheezing and gasping, she struggles to stand.

Moonsea Rising -20240310

The Sea Cave

Aboard the ship Harken has found them, Beitris alerts them to the coastline from her vision. The captain, promising to wait for further pay, allows them to use a dinghy, and they set out into the small cave, barely visible from the boat.

In the cave, they find a small cave, that ends after a few feet. Below the water, however, stairs extended into the water. Sighing, Lirael digs the shell of easy breathing out of the portable hole and starts filling it. She tells the others that the sea elves have temples to Damoden all throughout the Moonsea. Though she knows little of the worship of the sea god, she knows that his worshipers are often friendly with the sea life around them. Taevyn starts snapping on some small fins.

As they fill their lungs with the magical bubbles and enter the water, they tread briefly before angling downwards. Harken has a magic lantern, and they stay close to the bubble of light around him.

Entering a hallway at the base of the steps, they find several doors and a hallway branching off.

Taevyn motions to the nearest door, graven with a large, open-mouthed, sea creature, to ask if it's a Damodrite icon. Lirael is unaware, and he and Lennox enter the room to find a kind of dressing room, full of decaying wooden lockers and scraps of cloth.

As they move through the room to open the other door, a school of glowing blue fish swim from the room and towards the southern hallway. In the room, Taevyn and Lennox find a corroded chest. Lennox attempt to hack it with his axe, finding that an axe isn't very useful underwater.

However, the chest smashes easily enough, and a jellied tentacle lashes out at him. Lirael catches the movement, and throws her spear quickly at it, catching it two blows, though the slime seems not very impacted by the spear pokes. Harken peppers it with the shards of its smashed chest, slashing at it, but it absorbs most of the impact.

The pseudopod lashes out around Lennox, wrapping him up and squeezing him. He quickly breaks the creature's grasp, and smashes it with his axe, though it seems ineffective. Taevyn considers and points his ring of the dark sun at the creature. Magics blast it, pummelling the slime.

Lirael moves around Taevyn and fires a ray of frost into the creature, which strikes it freezing a large patch of its surface. It immediately moves to try and get away, though it has limited options. Harken messages Lennox to disengage from it and allow it to flee. Lennox instead smashes it with the side of the axe, and throws a punch, neither of which it's pleased with.

Taevyn does a complicated aquatic move that the effect of distracting the creature, but otherwise is of limited impact. Lirael tells Lennox to let it leave and clears the doorway. She readies another ray of frost; in case it doesn't flee. Harken tries to open the other door, but finds it locked. The slime tries to flee, dodging Lennox's kick as it goes.

In the remainder of the chest lies a key that fits the door lock to the next room. Harken checks for traps, and gestures everyone back while he opens the door. They find a massive room, extending well beyond the light of Harken's lantern. The vaulted ceiling is obscured by

seven-foot-tall sea grasses, and a large statue with an open-mouthed fishy statue of some description looms against the north wall. As Harken swims towards the ceiling to search the grass, Taevyn swims to observe the statue. Visions fill his mind of a non-Euclidean space filled with a malevolent presence.

The Sunken Horror

As he gapes at it, it begins to move, reaching out for him and the others. Taevyn attempts to tumble past it, stabbing it as it tries to take command of his mind. He is stunned by the enormity of its malice but fights off the intrusion. Beitris summons her spiritual weapon, which smash into the thing, harming it. With uncharacteristic abandon, she moves closer to the thing, preparing some protective magics.

Harken starts flashing his lantern at the statue, trying to distract it, before drawing an arrow from his quiver and using his psychic powers to propel it forward. Lennox swims forward, slowly swinging his axe through the water. He chops into it heavily twice, leaving it near death. Lirael considers the creature, but nothing obvious presents itself about the thing, and she fires the ray of frost at it. It compresses inexplicably, angles shifting through one another, and leaves onto the original statue behind. Among the rubble, a very fine magical crossbow with ice runes is found, which Taevyn eyes before hanging on his belt.

Lirael asks Beitris if any of the icons mean anything to her, but she has limited knowledge of the sea gods. Taevyn checks one of the side rooms, which appears to be filled with some kind of blackish brine but is otherwise empty. Swimming back, he and Lennox open the far door, revealing a room swarming with sea spiders of some sort.

He immediately slams the door, leaning his back against it. Swimming to the south, he opens the last door, finding a room full of giant crawfish. They are gathered around the far door but are easily dispatched by Lennox and Taevyn.

The Final Harken

They open the far door, revealing an altar, with another massive fish head behind it, the open mouth disappearing into darkness. From the darkness, a long eel-like creature comes forward, snapping a chunk out of Taevyn, and coiling around him, and pulling him back into the hole.

Lennox swims after them, grabbing Taevyn's feet and pulling backwards. Harken swims forward to help, but the eel manages to swallow him whole. Beitris watches in horror as the eel prepares to retreat with its meal. A lance of divine light flashes out from her, missing the eel.

Taevyn wriggles around, kicking and stabbing with his dagger, and manages to get the beast to disgorge him. He holds up his rapier to parry further strikes. Lirael swims into the room, using ray of frost again, since that has been very effective against the sea life. Lennox lashes out at it with his axe, but the eel is slippery, and he manages to miss it.

Harken tries to dig his dagger into the eel, to prevent it from retracting into its hole. It bites at him, preventing his attempt to pin its jaw with his dagger, and it he follows it up with his telekinesis. It lashes out at him, biting deeply into his torso. It coils around him and swallows him. Beitris flashes another divine lance, the light slashing at the eel. Taevyn does another fancy underwater move, rapier flashing and missing in the water. Lirael flashes out the ray of frost, throwing the spear after, but the latter misses.

Lennox continues chopping at the beast, trying to free Harken. He lands a single solid chop, but otherwise misses. Harken uses his telekinesis from within the thing's gullet, and tries to wriggle backwards, unsuccessfully. He loses consciousness as the eel's muscles work to break him down. Beitris tries to hit it with divine lance again but misses as Taevyn slashes at it repeatedly. Lirael moves forward, trying to get him free with the spear, but is unable to hit the eel.

Lennox continues chopping at the eel, but only manages to connect once. Inside of the eel, out of view of the party, Harken succumbs to his fate, the gods granting him his peace. In the back of his psyche, he reaches out, cursing this place and the beast that consumed him as his spirit departs the plane.

Beitris continues using divine lance, spirit damage lashing the beast, desperate to free Harken. Taevyn spins, rapier flashing, as he filets the beast, killing it. Beitris moves to it, chopping with the kukri, as Harken's body floats lifelessly from the eel. Tears mixing with the salt water, she takes some of his corpse for restoration purposes.

Lirael talks to General Tuskclaw, asking him if there is anything he can do. He says not, then corrects that there is nothing worth doing. She pushes, asking him what Gruumsh can do. He remains silent.

Moonsea Rising -20240406

Dark Thoughts

As Beitris tries to compose Harken's corpse, Taevyn pops the invisibility ring off his finger and slips in his pocket, looking slightly guilty in the process.

Lennox begins butchering the eel, looking for pieces of value. Lirael asks if they have any way to protect Harken's corpse until their return. Beitris protects him with Lathander's blessings, and they shut the doors behind themselves to hopefully keep him whole. The party licks their wounds, both physically and spiritually, before they head further to the south.

At the end of the corridor is a door with "this way," written in common. Behind it is a ten-by-ten room with four doors on each a wall, and an arrow on the floor made of rocks and shells. It says, "getting closer," and while Lirael is in favour of following the only direction they have until proven false, Beitris has a bad feeling about it. She asks Taevyn to check the other doors first.

He finds the eastern one locked. Without any tools to hand, Lennox shoulders his ax and begins awkwardly chopping through it underwater. Taevyn levels the ring of the dark sun at it, and it is blasted to flinders, floating away.

A stair leading into a jumbled rockfall grace the middle of the room. In the weeds to the south, something furtive moves in the weeds. It swishes forward as Lennox bellows defiance at it, and Taevyn struggles with his crossbow. A draconic turtle, clearly surprised by Lennox's yell, swims towards Lennox, raking him with its claws repeatedly, and snapping its jaws on the big man.

Lirael takes in the scene. The turtle looks sickly, but still strong, and its shell is thick. It doesn't look like it can clear the doorway, however. Calling to Lennox to flee the room, she casts a web of sticky vines at the thing, snaring it. Taevyn instead dives around the thing, lashing out with his rapier and scoring a savage slash across an exposed leg. Floating in place, he raises his rapier to ward off a retaliation.

Beitris steps forward, healing Lennox for most of the damage done. Lennox lashes out with his axe, landing a serious blow to the creature. Frenzied by its wounds, it lashes out at Taevyn, hitting him with a claw, but exposing its neck on its bite. Taevyn tries to take advantage, but the turtle snaps its head back, the blow glancing off his shell. Lirael renews her vines, but the thing is only slowed, not immobilized.

Taevyn stabs with the rapier again, killing the beast. Lirael notices a message scratched in the wall beside the door to the turtle's room. Wiping away some lichens, she finds, "B, L, T, don't go through locked door; very large turtle."

Beitris immediately thinks the message is intended for them. Lirael is sceptical, but as they themselves are misplaced in time, perhaps others are as well. The turtle could have been quite ancient, but the inscription looked hundreds of years old.

Deciding that perhaps the inscriptions are in their favour, they follow the door out of the room. Finding another hallway with a door at the far end that says, "here", they move to it and open it.

Harken's Return

In the room, they find a giant octopus, floating above the grasses, holding a human skull. As Taevyn's eyes widen, Lirael addresses it in thalassic.

"Who are you?"

"Not who I am. Who this is!"

"Well, who is it?"

"I have a friend of yours."

She reaches out for the skull, and Harken's voice speaks in her mind.

He tells her he's been trapped here for over 220 years, bound to the skull (his, he claims), which the octopus is holding. Taevyn asks if he has the artifact, which Harken does not, though he knows a safe path, but for the final guardian, a fearsome kraken living in a deep shaft at the south of the complex.

Lirael sense Gruumsh's magic in the skull. She asks Harken if he knows how he came to be bound to the skull. He doesn't know for sure, but he believes it to have been Gruumsh's intervention. General Tuskclaw pipes up in her brain, telling her he also senses Gruumsh's hand in this.

She tells Harken that his body is nearby, despite his personal temporal issues. But, perhaps, they should retrieve the Lathandrite artifact and perhaps the power of the two gods will be able to restore him further.

The octopus, Karl, thanks Harken for his companionship but releases him to his friends. Karl tells her that this Harken is not the one that goes with the body they left behind. Lirael thanks him for the aid he has rendered, and after collecting some gems Harken has gathered over the centuries, they take their leave.

The Well

As Harken leads them to the deep pit he knows as The Well, Lirael asks him about his ability to interact with the physical world. He tells her he has some limited ability to use his telekinesis, but it's taxing. Beitris stops them, however, suggesting they return to the surface to prepare for a dangerous combat. Harken redirects, and leads them back towards the surface, where they find the ochre jelly blocking their path. It starts undulating towards them.

Beitris notices it first, and fires a crossbow bolt at it, but it has limited effect. As Taevyn braces for it to reach them, Lennox rushes forward, charging the creature, battering it with the flat of his axe.

The jelly lashes out with a pseudopod, battering and burning him with its acid, and wrapping it around him. Taevyn fires his crossbow, whose cold magics seem to affect it somewhat, as Lirael blasts it with a ray of frost, cracking it in several places.

Harken reaches out his hand to it, and the jelly starts breaking apart, streams of it roiling into his incorporeal form. Lirael's eyes narrow as she recognizes the death magics he's using, and wonders what it portends.

Lennox swings the axe sideways again, crushing the jelly despite the water resistance. Surface-side, they heal up and find a place to bed down, along the shoreline.

Returning to the well, they find a door with a glowing keyhole. Harken knows the well is behind the door, but he doesn't know where the key is. Beitris thinks the runes around the door resemble ancient Lathandrite script, but she's unable to read it. She recites an ancient prayer to Lanthander, which causes the door to begin streaming coruscating lights. A purple glow in the shape of her holy symbol draws her eye, and she places hers in it. The door vanishes.

Down a hallway, a giant sea creature is lurking. It looks badly injured, and swims out of their sight as soon as the door opens.

Harken addresses it in thalassic, and it tells them they will die if they come to retrieve the ring it guards. Beitris is confused, as her vision was of a jewelled dagger.

As they discuss what to do, Lennox and Taevyn think about the best way to attack the creature. Harken tells it they are prepared to die. The water fills with poisonous ink, causing those still breathing to choke and gag.

In the inky blackness, the creature swims up and bludgeons Lennox badly. He swings at it, but the giant beast is slippery, and he cannot see. Gagging, Taevyn retreats from the room into the hallway.

Lirael mentally looks at the General and closes her remaining eye. In the darkness, the kraken's curious voice rings out, "what is your command, my master."

Lirael speaks, her voice harsh. "Retreat. We must see what is in the well."

The sea horror recedes into the dark of its room, and the ink clears. Lirael's legs go weak, and she begins retching. As Beitris moves to the party, cleansing the poison and healing everyone up, she pushes herself weakly upright again. However, the poison continues to act. Beitris clears it from Lennox, and the man straightens. As she works to remove it from herself, Lirael collapses, vomit erupting from her mouth as her body goes limp. As Harken stabilizes her, Beitris removes her poison as well, healing up herself and the others again.

As Lirael's remaining eye opens, Taevyn asks her how long her spell on the creature will last. Groggily, she responds that it should last long enough for their purposes. Tuskclaw speaks in her mind, "Good thing you're back, I cannot hold this thing back without you as a focus."

In the depths of the well, they do, in fact, find the jewelled dagger they expected. Beitris lifts it reverently. Lirael, looks on, her skin pale, single eye glittering like an emerald.

Moonsea Rising -20240421

Gotta Go Back in Time

Combining the powers of the dagger and the chest, General Tuskclaw directs Lirael in the ritual to return them to their own time. Returning to Melvaunt, Lirael performs the ritual. The colour rushes out of the world, and their spirits are pulled through a rushing purple twilight.

As they "approach" their own time, something feels wrong. Lirael feels a pain in her missing eye socket, and the dagger pulses in Beitris' hand. So fast it could be mistaken, the colours towards which they are rushing divert to the side, and a different set of colours return to the world.

Looking around, Lirael notices subtle changes to her friends. Taevyn is sporting a scar across his cheek, Lennox looms even larger, Beitris' eyes have lightening to the point of being a dazzling blue rather than their prior dark brown. Even the shade of Harken is altered, sporting shock-white hair and goatee. Lirael seems unaffected, which is somehow even stranger.

Looking down at her hand, Beitris sees she's holding a tarot card depicting the dagger which she had just been holding. The air has a caustic smell, and it tingles in the back of their throats.

Beitris posits that they might not have returned to the present they left, and Taevyn wonders at the heavier make of furniture in the room. Cautiously, they troop out of the rented room, and head down the stairs.

In the common area of the tavern, they find the building much the same, but for 200 years of progress. However, "civilized" orcs are interspersed with the other races. Taevyn immediately attempts to draw his rapier. Lirael casts charm on him, but he resists, as Lennox puts his arm around the smaller man, counselling stillness. He points out that this clearly isn't an invasion, and Taevyn's father might well still be alive in this timeline.

Several of the orcs, noticing Lirael, make small gestures in her direction. She returns the gesture of the one-eyed god to them. Lennox suggests they have a drink before exiting, but Lirael and Beitris suggest getting Taevyn out sooner might be better.

Outside, the air is heavy with industrial byproducts. The docks appear to be only half as developed as they remember. The ships have substantial icebreaking gear affixed to them. It clear that the Moonsea is much changed, since Laronen's spell had prevented it from icing over, in the time they came from.

Realizing that the Empire might be much changed, or in fact, non-existent, they think that perhaps visiting the Temple of Lathandar and checking its archives might be in order.

The smog is choking. Taking inspiration from the locals, the party covers their faces with cloth from their clothing or packs, attempting to filter out the worst of the particulate.

Turning down a side street, they encounter a group of halflings accosting a well-dressed orc. The orc calls out to them for assistance, the lead halfling warns them off, gesturing to several compatriots on nearby rooftops.

Beitris immediately moves to cover, drawing her crossbow, as the halflings move to attack. They begin firing crossbows at Taevyn, as Beitris returns fire. One of them hits him a dead eye shot, and he whirls and spins towards them, attempting to distract their further shots.

Sprinting to the nearest attacker, he runs him through with his rapier, wounding the halfling badly. Lenox charges forward, slashing a second one. As they see these two horrific attacks, they turn to flee, Lirael flashing a ray of frost at one, and nearly freezing him in place. They turn and flee headlong down the street.

The injured halfling drops his arms in surrender. The orc congratulates them and tells them he'll be turned over to the Bruleicos. Guards show up, and the orc, Baron Luther Ironclaw, calls them over. They tell the halfling he'll be hanged for attacking a noble.

The Baron, the Tharan Ambassador, thanks them profusely, and asks if they'll accompany him to the bazaar, and take a meal at his embassy. He enquires after their names, recognizing both Beitris and Lirael's families. He notes that Edric, whom Taevyn asks after, is a character in a card game called "War for the Crown", which he identifies Beitris' card as belonging to. He tells them there is a game shop quite near his friend's store where they can likely acquire more cards.

How Bazaar

Following the Baron to the bazaar, he points them to the game shop, Three Moves Ahead, and tells them he'll send them a dinner invite via the Marsks.

As they approach the game shop, they hear a blood-curdling scream, prompting Taevyn to sprint to the door with rapier drawn. Inside, they find chalk lines smearing in the blood of dead woman. Some giant beast looms over her, and a couple of thugs along the walls call to the monster, "don't worry, Boss. We got this."

They charge Taevyn with spears. Taevyn tumbles through them, striking back, they continue to poke him with their spears. Lennox roars and rushes in, swinging his axe. Meanwhile, some presence speaks in Beitris' mind, and when she responds, she winces at its response. The creature glares directly at her. As she casts about for an action to take, Lirael fires a bolt of searing light at it, hitting with a light of burning holy fire. Harken tries to leech its lifeforce with his unholy powers, but the creature laughs off his attempts.

Taevyn spins the spearmen around, stabbing with his rapier. The spearman raises his shield, absorbing some of the blow, but it's still a grievous strike. The spearman attacking Lennox tells him, "The boss is gonna feast on your soul." He attempts to grab the big man but fails to do so.

Lennox whirls his axe in a wide arc, obliterating both spearmen at a stroke. The beast turns its baleful glare on him. Beitris moves forward, calling on Lathandar's blessing, as Lirael fires another searing ray, which misses.

The creature skitters forward, swinging his tail at the three in the building. Taevyn flips the tail, and Lennox knocks it off his shoulder, but Beitris is knocked down. It snaps its jaws at her, but misses. Harken summons a phantasm, but the creature snaps its jaws on it, dispersing it.

As Taevyn looks at the downed Beitris, she yells for him to get out. He tells her, "Not until you're clear." He tumbles past the beast, stabbing with his rapier. It clatters off its bones, rattling through its ribs. Lennox smashes the creature three massive blows with his axe, bones flying apart, and nearly decapitating the beast.

It disappears. Invisibly, its tail lashes Lennox to the floor, and renders Beitris insensate. It chomps down on her, leaving her mangled and near death. In her mind, it gloats, "creature of a weak god, you will learn true power this day."

Harken wafts towards the door, and casts sanctuary on Beitris. He looks for the beast but doesn't see it. Taevyn pulls out his crossbow, and fires into the beast, hitting it. Lennox rushes it, smashing it with his axe and breaking it to pieces. Its bones immediately begin sinking through the floor.

As Beitris heals herself, Harken looks at the chalk drawings on the floor, wondering aloud, "why is it a map of Melvaunt?" Two different coloured lines appear to track something moving from the docks, and something coming from the east gate. The path from the docks appears to follow the party's actions. Beitris' card still seems to point to the northwest.

Exploring the room to the north, they find several games, including lower-quality copies of cards like Beitris'. In a nearby ledger, they also find a similarly high-quality card representing Laronen. Beitris' card follows Laronen's around, though his card seems inert.

Looking at the ledger, they find a name circled, Dieral Myrnese.

Back in the main room, Harken speaks with the memories of the deceased spearman. They tell him that they were tracking the cards. They are from War for the Crown, but the ones they were tracking are special. There is a dozen in a full deck.

Sifting through the cards, they find cards for:

1. the Mage
2. the Dagger
3. the Quartermaster
4. the Drake Talon
5. the Emperor
6. the Zhent
7. the Mad King
8. the Chieftain
9. the General
10. the Chest
11. the Temple
12. and the Druid.

Moonsea Rising -20240505

Friday Night Magic

At Lennox's questioning, Lirael opens the portable hole and finds the tarot of The Chest, rather than the chest she was expecting. Reaching out in her mind, she finds the General still there.

Quickly sketching the map from the floor, they move to track the other points that were being tracked by the shop owner, before malign forces find them. The nearest is Historia Reliquery. Arakinesh the Wise introduces himself, asking them what they're seeking. Taevyn immediately asks about The War of the Crown. He is immediately dismissive.

Harken whispers to Lirael about getting some local histories. She notes that there are several magical tomes, as well as something in a small box on the counter behind him.

Lirael asks him about books on the history of the region, and he mentions having works on Melvaunt, Thar, and Tuscabibble's History of the Mad King. She tells him the latter, of which he has five of the six volumes, is probably too nice an item for their travels, but the former two are certainly of interest.

Beitris finds a work on the noble houses of Melvaunt, and recognizes the crests of Marsk, Brule, Shadowbanks, Norster, Larrigen, and Barrigen. She doesn't see Kilaudra, Tuscabibble, Moje, or El Gata. She asks him about Tuscabibble's Guide, and he tells her it was written by Rudolpho Tuscabibble at least 150 years ago. She haggles with him briefly, before buying it at the outrageous 15gp he asks.

Harken messages Lirael, asking if maybe he should reveal himself. She's doubtful on that but suggests that if he can see what's in the box, that would be useful. Making himself invisible, he sneaks over and sees that it's The Talon.

Lennox manages to haggle him down on a history of Thar. Arakinesh becomes much more talkative and asks Lirael about her eye patch. She tells him she's sacrificed it to Gruumsh, and he becomes excited. He shows her a tarot of the Chieftan, whom he believes to be Lorfax, possibly the first King of Thar. He describes it as the pride of his collection, and Lirael expresses interest in buying it. He offers it for 75gp. She counters that he should allow her to identify it first.

She finds the card is a mimic, possibly used for cheating at cards. He fumes about Dieral Myrnes selling him garbage and offers Lirael the first volume of the Mad King in apology. She decides to buy the rest of the set, and he is ecstatic. When Beitris asks, he tells her that Dieral is friendly with Clemeth at the Reclaimed Paradise, and a collector of tattoos, so he might be found at the Kraken's Ink.

Beitris' card is still pointing towards the back of the shop, so they step outside to see if it's pointing beyond the shop, which it appears to be. Belaying following that for the moment, they follow the map they made to the second shop in the bazaar, which turns out to be Kraken's Ink.

Nautically themed and smelling of salt, they find the proprietor talking to a man who is looking at his book for possible new art. Taevyn immediately asks him if he can do a magical triangle teeth tattoo. While he does the tattoo, Lennox and Beitris butter him up, and find out that he did a tattoo that looked very much like Lirael with a giant lizard for Dieral earlier that day.

Leaving and following the card, they find it directing them well towards the east gate, until it shifts hard-right before a compound by the gate. As Beitris wanders over to the gate, she sees the destrier in the paddock is exceedingly well-cared-for. Taevyn goes to knock on the door of the main building, getting no response. Harken peeks through the wall, finding someone sitting quietly in the dark, looking around and hoping to go unnoticed. He has a stack of cards with him.

Taevyn picks the outside lock, and they enter, calling for Dieral. Harken gestures to the small room, and Dieral tells them he's not there. When Taevyn opens his door, he begs them not to kill him, telling them the cards have shown him visions of them coming to kill him.

Taevyn asks him about the cards. He looks scared and says, "no, no, no," as several men storm into the barn.

Give Me that Shiny Rare

The attackers begin firing arrows at Dieral, telling him he knows why they're here to kill him. A creature with several bizarre limbs attacks Harken's mind with crushing despair. Beitris summons her spiritual weapon, swinging it at one of the attackers, as another fells Lirael in two swift stabs of her rapier. A massive, red-skinned humanoid sizes up Lennox, and steps up to attack him, grinning. He smashes the large man with his axe, and tells him "if you leave now, I won't kill you." Lennox attacks him back, at the man laughs.

Dieral slams the inner door in Taevyn's face as the younger man calls him a coward. Harken struggles against the magical emotions swirling through him and stabilizes Lirael before she can die. Taevyn tumbles through the big man, slashing at him, and takes an arrow from one of the assassins. They fire on Lennox as well, striking him with several arrows. The inhuman mage casts a series of magical missiles at Taevyn, then ducks back outside and under cover.

Beitris tells the large man, "I will take what I came for and leave. But one must pay the price. You choose." Beitris heals the room, and the commander demands she name someone, or the deal is off. She offers herself, as Lennox and Taevyn both move to intercept her.

Lirael, however, stands up. Looking at the red-skinned man. She declaims, "I demand you take your men and leave." He points at her and says, "this isn't over," and turns to leave.

She collapses back to the floor as they depart. Taevyn rushes over to her with his healing kit and begins working on her. As everyone stares on, aghast, her skin begins to darken, her features roughen, and small tusks extrude from lower jaw. Beitris casts another large heal, closing her wounds, but she doesn't immediately regain consciousness.

Moonsea Rising -20240519

Building the Playset

Dieral tells them the card, The Talon, had given him visions of the devil coming to kill him. He offers it to them, along with a couple of salamander elixirs he has made. He is afraid the devil will return for the card. He is devout fan of the War for the Crown and shows them a tattoo of "The Druid". Highly stylized, a little pin-uppy, it shows an elf in a low-cut green dress, with an eye patch, and a dinosaur in the background. Lirael's good eye narrows slightly, but she doesn't say anything.

Taevyn asks Dieral if he knows anyone else with the rare variants. He only knows of the two shops to which they've been. He takes Lirael's advice to not be found by the devil, thinking maybe he'll relocate to Phlan.

Discussing where to get off the streets, they recall passing the sign for the Cock and Bull on their way to the bazaar. Several of the party members remember it from their last visit to the city, and they make their way there. The proprietor, Garth, has rooms for long-term let, and is more than willing to rent. The bar is full of many races drinking and having fun. Though Melvaunt is more racially diverse than it used to be, elves seem to be quite rare. The party elects to get some rooms, and beds down for the night.

Sun and Storm

They all share a vivid dream in which they are together at the doors to a large structure, which dream-Beitris identifies as the Opera House in her original Melvaunt, which had become the House of Sun and Storm. It stands alone, rather than in its traditional context. The doors swing open, and they all feel compelled to enter. Inside, they find the temple as it was, full of priests and penitents, engaged in normal worship.

At the altar, a high priest unfamiliar to Beitris is preaching, and she doesn't recognize the other priests or the flock. Looking around, Beitris moves to sit in the pews up front. Lirael prods the pews with her toe, wondering at the reality of everything, but it all seems solid. Beitris listens attentively as the High Priest praises Edric, talking of his sacrifices, and postulating the awfulness that might have been if he had not done what he did. Trade, sea frost, orcish raids; all these things are no longer, thanks to Edric. And for all these good works, Edric was beatified to sit at the right hand of Lathander.

As the service ends, the party turns at a loud, sarcastic, slow clap coming from the back of the temple. There, the devil smirks, deriding the sermon's content, though none other than the party seem to hear him. Taevyn leaps up, drawing his rapier, and telling everyone to take cover while they take care of it. The devil laughs, telling them he will soon take their cards from them, for his master. He leaves, telling them he will see them soon in the waking world.

Harken notes that he refers to the dream of the temple as "holy ground." He thinks that consecrated ground might weaken the devil, while Lirael thinks extended imprisonment might well kill it. The high priest moves through the parishioners, greeting them. When he sees Beitris, he clasps her hands and tells her "reclaimed paradise" will be her's. Taevyn asks her about that, and she tells him the Church in her time was quite corrupt, but "reclaimed paradise" isn't any doctrine of which she's aware.

Lirael is studying the parishioners' attire and tells them to look at it. It seems more like the time in which they began than the time in which they find themselves. She also says she

thought the devil looked surprised to see them, so wonders why they are in this dream. She examines The Talon, finding its aura divine. She wonders if it is the reason they were brought to where the devil was.

Exiting the temple, they no find themselves on a short representation of the street of Melvaunt. At one end of the street is an older temple to Selne; at the other is a palisade which appears to be the entrance to the temple of Xul'jarak.

Return to Xul'jarak

Beitris recalls that Jessica Talianos, captain of the Silverswords, was a priestess of Selne. She passes this information along, but suggests they explore Xul'jarak. There are no guards, and they make their way to the main room. The chest and the floating entity are present, and as Lirael makes her way to the chest. In her mind, she can feel the General's excitement. As she pulls out the card to compare, the entity speaks. "You have done so much, but you can do more. What will you choose?"

She reaches out to the General in her mind, and he exults in what they've already done. She asks him what more they can do, but he doesn't which to say. The entity, likewise, tells her she can do anything she likes. Harken suggests they collect all the cards and make reality whatever they like. She's still a little uncomfortable with that but does want to ensure peace among the intelligent races. Taevyn wants the devils stopped, and Lirael asks what their goal is. The entity tells her that the devils clearly want the cards to make choices, or to prevent others from making choices. He names the devil, Vharnev the Butcher, at which Beitris' ears perk up.

While the entity speaks of choices, he offers none. Beitris, impatient to see what the Goddess of the Moon has to offer them, moves to leave for the Temple of Selne. The others follow, with Taevyn waiting on Lirael before he leaves. He tells her perhaps the cards can make her fully elven again. She smiles and says that her sacrifice was necessary, and she doesn't regret it. He mentions that she was prettier before her transformation, for which she thanks him.

The Moon

Heading towards the Temple of the Moon, they find a fourth structure on their dream street -- the Laronium. Entering the temple, they instead find themselves in a warehouse with racks and racks of silvered arms and armour. Paladins and their squires bustle about getting outfitted. A large table under a chandelier has Jessica and others planning an attack against the Zhentarim. She greets them as though she'd been expecting them and turns back to planning an attack on Zhentil Keep.

She has tokens representing the Zhent forces, including a red figure with a giant axe, and a man with stag horns. Beitris immediately engages Jessica, speaking about the battle plans, and asking about Vharnev and the druid. Jessica says they know little about the druid, and asks Beitris what she knows, but she knows even less. Jessica says Edric is going to use the chest to breach the walls of the Keep so the Silverswords can exterminate the Zhentarim.

As Harken and Beitris theory craft about what Vharnev might want, she notices that the planning doesn't seem to be progressing. The scene they're in seems to be static, as though it were a simple slice of time. Beitris is getting bored, as she wonders what they're supposed to see in this dream, and Lirael wonders why the card, she assumes, has brought them here.

The Wizard's House

They check out the Laronium, finding an arcane library par excellence. A rather pompous librarian directs them to a tome on reality-bending artifacts which seems rather pointed about not using powerful artifacts without centuries of study. Beitris finds a spellbook with two spells she can read: outcasts' curse and crushing despair.

Deciding that the group is under attack by dream magic, Beitris forces herself to wake up, disappearing from the Laronium. Keeping her eyes closed, she tries to sense any unexpected presences in the room but detects nothing. Grabbing a weapon, she quickly searches the suite. Finding a copy of the game they grabbed on a table; the board is out and set up. It is places of import in the game, and it looks poorly made, other than four locations in the game which appear in vibrant, bright colour. Unsurprisingly, it's the Laronium, The Temples of Sun and Storm, Selne, and Xul'jarak.

She wakes the others, explaining what she found. Lirael says she doesn't think anyone has set up the game, but rather the magics are interacting with one another. Examining the board game rules, they find the cards are affiliated with gaining access to a benefit on a region of the board game. It is about the founding of the Empire, and the highest possible score is achieved by doing what was done in their timeline. The Dagger card allows the player to declare their move last, with knowledge of all other moves.

The cards as well allow access to a metaphysical representation of places that provide them with additional powers. Beitris mentions that The Dagger is still pointing towards the market, and Lirael wants to spend more time studying the rules, to see what the other cards might portend or where they might be found.

Moonsea Rising -20240602

The Sun Still Rises

In the morning, waking from their night's ordeal, they find a formal invitation to Baron Ironclaw's dinner. It specifies, in no uncertain terms, that they arrive in formalwear. Beitris has her ceremonial vestments, but the others aren't so lucky. Asking about, they find a couple of off-duty tailors talking shop in the taproom of the Cock and Bull. Rivals, they begin lobbying the party to use their respective firms. The Velvet Blade and Silverweave's Fine Threads. Based on the Velvet Blade's tailor being an ore, and knowing who had invited them, and their rather unsavoury prior association with House Silverweave, they follow the tailor to The Velvet Blade.

Finding a fine, Saville Row-style establishment, filled with the factors of noble houses and protected from the sooty outside air by magical air, they are greeted by Serge, the flamboyant tailor. He acts as though he cannot possibly accommodate Lennox on their timeframe but changes his mind quickly at the mention of Silverweave.

He sizes up the three corporeal party members who need attire and gets fast to his task when he hears for what the outfits are needed. Lirael tells him she needs something unique, which incorporates the eye patch appropriately. He charges them a pretty penny for the clothes and tells them they may return in a few hours to retrieve them.

Paradise Regained

Leaving the Velvet Blade, Beitris surreptitiously consults the Dagger, which leads them to a salvage yard by the side gate on the western edge by the docks. A sign, in Orcish, reads "Reclaimed Paradise". Taevyn immediately recalls the odd phrase the priest said to Beitris in their dream. The Reclaimed Paradise is a bustle with activity, largely ores and gnomes, but conspicuously no humans. Consulting The Dagger, Beitris makes her way to the office under the guise of securing appropriate transport for the evening.

The owner, Clemeth Faulk, greets them and asks how she can help. A burly ore with comically deep goggles, she notices Lennox and asks if he was ever a competitive athlete. Beitris quietly tells Taevyn and Lirael to keep an eye out in case they are ambushed again. The lines of sight from the elevated shed are quite clear, and they watch as several people are running and jumping around the salvage.

Clemeth is soliciting Lennox for some professional event. She suggests that if he performs well on the obstacle course, there could be a good discount for them. The obstacle course is curiously free of soot in its air, again as though the winds are behaving. Taevyn and Lennox rush outside to try it, as everyone on the lot gathers around. Beitris and Lirael take this opportunity to check The Dagger and try and figure out where it's pointing.

In the middle of the room, the plans appear to be a massive, hundreds of feet long, iron vehicle, which apparently runs on tracks, and has amenities like a casino and a dining room. She points them out to Lirael, and the two suss out that it's some kind of locomotive engine of gnomish design, which runs on rails. There's also a small pocket in the plans which is slightly thickened, and Lirael's detect magic shows something there.

Outside, Lennox blasts his way through the obstacle course, battering things aside like a bull in a china shop. Takes the second attempt, studying the larger man's progress, and dances

through it, avoiding the swinging elements in the larger man's wake, and beats the larger man's time, but barely.

Clemeth is impressed and asks Taevyn if he'd ever considered competing in the arena. He says he would have, but his mom wouldn't let him.

Inside, Beitris locates and swaps the card of The Chieftain, pocketing the magical version. She and Lirael head outside as Clemeth is talking to the other two, potentially trying to talk them into competing in the arena.

Clemeth offers them a 20% discount on anything they might need. Lennox shows some interest in the plans and tells them she's trying to build the first line between Melvaunt and Tgorsk, in Thar. She claims it can dramatically cut travel time between the cities. Beitris asks if she needs investors, and Clemeth tells her that House Marsk isn't exactly on good terms with the Kingdom of Thar. Beitris suggests that maybe private investment, not affiliated with her House might be more welcome, and Clemeth tells them to come back another time to discuss it.

As they're leaving, Beitris asks Clemeth if she knows a famous equestrian gladiator named Nikolai Steele.

Steele. She furrows her substantial brow. "No gladiators named Steele, though there is a man named 'Nikolai' from Penaris. But he's a thug, associated with a group of bandits." Beitris asks about the bandits, and finds they're named The Iron Fist, led by Uriah the Fist. As they leave, Taevyn mentions quietly to Beitris, "my father's name was Uriah."

In the Ghetto

As they make their way back to the Cock and Bull, they find themselves moving through a warren of hovels when arrows begin to rain down on them. Taevyn and Lennox both take arrows as the assassins move in. Lennox moves forward, hewing away with his axe as Taevyn goes into his kata. He cuts the man between him and Lennox, leaving him bleeding heavily as he whirls into a parry.

Beitris summons a Seraphim, which immediately besets the archer on the roof, which moves to flee it. A bolt flies from her forehead to the nearest assassin. Considering the wisdom it imparts; she attempts to command the furthest assassin to "leave this place and report us slain." He seems unperturbed from her attempted control.

Two of assassins carefully draw dripping arrows from their quivers and fire at Taevyn and Lirael. They are both struck, and Taevyn immediately begins retching. The assassin by Taevyn draws a similarly envenomed dagger and slashes at Taevyn, missing him twice. The furthest bowman draws his poisoned arrow, but nicks himself with it, gagging and wobbling on his feet, as his arrow goes well wide of Lennox. The big man swings his axe, chopping heavily into the dagger-wielding assassin. Taevyn retches repeatedly, trying to keep his rapier between himself and his attacker.

Beitris' Seraphim swoops down on the daggerman, missing him, and Beitris heals herself, as her wounds are the most grievous. Meanwhile, the penultimate assassin fires his poisoned arrow, striking the priestess heavily, though she resists the venom. Lirael summons a thin shield of magical glass around herself, and casts a primal spell at Lennox, who seems to grow larger and more intimidating. The final poison arrow is drawn, but this bowman manages to cut himself as well, doubling over as his guts twist and cramp.

The nearest assassin moves his hands, and a fiery ring opened beneath him, into which he drops. Lennox manages to land a massive blow on him, and the man flops lifelessly into hole, blood gushing from a dozen wounds. A sickened assassin retches, trying to clear the poison from his system. Light blooms from Beitris, as healing bathes the party, and the Seraphim returns to its plane of existence.

A refreshed Lennox charges the nearest assassin, striking him a glancing blow. Sickened, Taevyn lurches along behind him, slashing at the assassin, but his illness robs him of his strength. Lirael mutters something and turns into a massive panther, slinking behind the nearest crates for cover. Doing a backflip up onto the crates, the assassin drops an arrow shot directly on Lennox, wounding the big man. Taevyn continues to take fire from the assassin on the roof near him. The furthest assassin fires three shots at Lirael, knocking her immediately unconscious. Beitris emits another bloom of magical healing, waking Lirael and bolstering Lennox.

Lennox leaps onto the roof, striking at the assassin nearest him. Taevyn tries to leap on the roof following but doesn't make the leap. The assassin draws his rapier and slashes at Taevyn, cutting him badly. Lirael climbs to her feet and tackles the nearby assassin from the boxes, snapping her jaws at him and missing. The assassins call to fire on Beitris, and several arrows hit her in short succession. She moves to cover, healing herself as she goes.

Lennox unleashes a flurry of blows, smashing the assassin next to him, and shifts down the roof line for a better position. Taevyn attempts to flip up onto the edge of the roof but botches the move and tries to swing over to surprise the man above him. He doesn't quite manage it, and slashes at the man, catching him a glancing blow. He steps away from the two and prepares his escape portal.

Meanwhile, the assassin by Lirael switches to his rapier, and misses her in steady succession. She leaps over him onto the roof, clawing and biting at the one trying to escape. She catches him a glancing blow with her claw, but he continues fumbling for his talisman. Beitris steps out, firing a divine lance at the escaping man, who keeps his feet. Filled with Lirael's magic, Lennox opens his mouth and screams. Primal sound wracks the nearby assassins, killing the fleeing man as the other two cover their ears. He moves into position as Taevyn tumbles up behind the standing assassin, slashing him with his rapier.

The assassins break and begin fleeing. The one between Taevyn and Lennox throws his arm up in the air and falls upwards into a fiery hole above him. Lirael springs across the square, leaping on the far roof and biting the last assassin, as he drops through to world.

Beitris and Taevyn grab their healer's kits, stitching up the various remaining wounds and damage, so they might at least be presentable. Taevyn inspects the dead assassins, finding good equipment, and signet rings with a horned skull insignia. Lirael and Lennox both recognize it as a diabolic symbol, and they radiate magic.

Moonsea Rising -20240615

Dinner at the Ironclaw's

As butlers and servants welcome the party into Baron Ironclaw's, he introduces the party to the others already in attendance:

- Terrian El Gata, fabulous merchant
- Doran Ma, fantastic person from Mulmaster
- Clemeth Faulk, associate on the Ironride Project
- Tomag Silverweave, a fine tailor
- Kia Kiulaudra, of House Caladra, pioneers of the relationship between Thar and Melvaunt
- Baroness Hermiphony Ironclaw, a talented ironsmith

As the party circulates during the drinks phase of the evening, Betris approaches Clemeth to talk more about the Ironride. Her Marsk blood throbs at the thought of extracting pecuniary reward from what Clemeth is working on. She finds that Clemeth is deeply invested in the relationship between Melvaunt and Thar and isn't a fan of obsequious flattery. Lirael speaks to the Baron, finding out that his hobby is demonology, and he's published scholarly works on them. He lets slip that the Kingdom of Thar is a major investor in a rail project. Lennox follows Betris, enthusiastic about the construction of the train. Clemeth is happy with so much attention to the project and tells them that the gems which power the spells are so valuable that the locomotive is a major bandit target.

Harken talks to Kia and Terrian, making small talk and trying to encourage him to simply loosen his tongue. He makes a couple of cryptic remarks about access to credit in the Moonsea and finds that the man considers it a backwards region in which to do high-level business. Taevyn sees Kia Kiulaudra as closest to his age and station and starts trying to chat to her about the party and dancing.

Beitris talks to Clemeth about the value of security measures for the train, to help allay her concerns about banditry. She suggests a variety of screening and security measures. Clemeth lights up on this point and calls the Baron over to share Beitris' ideas. They are both interested in the idea that possibly the group might be useful in securing the train. Finding that to be well in hand, Lirael drifts over to the Baroness, talking to her about her ironworks. She tells Lirael that's she's invented a form of steel that is extremely resistant to magic, while also being very conductive. Rather than wheels, the train will be using that technology for the rail. She's pleased that Thar has seen fit to invest so much in her work.

Lennox continues talking about railway security and suggests employing the arena fighters as bulls to secure both the train and the stations, possibly as a trans-national security force, controlled by the rail company. Clemeth and the Baron are both impressed by this idea. Harken, feigning stomach issues to cover for his future needs to skip dinner. Watching everything that's going on, he notes Terrian seems frustrated by his inability to speak to the Baron alone, which Tomag seems quite put out by Taevyn's interest in Kia Kiulaudra, and not subtly. He also catches Doran Ma's eye, as the man seems to be doing the same thing.

When a particular air starts up, Taevyn very formally invites Kia to dance with him. She takes him up on his offer, and is impressed by his dancing, though Tomag seems rather more upset than before. Beitris continues to talk to the Baron about rail security, and he confides that he's most concerned about organized political resistance, including from the Iron Fist -- whom he goes on at length about, Uriah the Fist, Nikolai the Bloody, red face-paint representing the orcish blood they've spilled, and their genocidal motto "from Galaina, to Moonsea," about killing all the orcs. They have killed thousands of orcs. Most other impediments can be bought off or turned aside, but the Iron Fist is different.

Lirael comes up to the Baron and tries to make some room for him to talk to Terrian El Gata. The Baron is clearly visibly appreciative of Lirael's appearance, and Harken notices the Baroness catching his gaze. Lennox talks to Clemeth about her dietary ideas, looking for an advantage in the arena. She explains to him about breads and beers, and how the reduce healing. He nods along, mentally crossing things off his list.

Harken tries to convince the Baroness that escorting the Baron to speak to Terrian might get him away from Lirael, to which she's receptive. Pushing past Lirael, she directs the two to the corner, turning others away from them. Taevyn continues flattering Kia, oblivious to the happenings in the rest of the room.

Beitris drifts over to Doran Ma, asking him if he's enjoying the show so far. With a smile and wink he tells her he's not sure who is going to explode first, Tomag or Hermiphony. He tells her she's quite perceptive, and his consulting of the cards told him he would meet someone interesting tonight, but he didn't expect it to be a Cleric of Lathander. She tells him she's the, "other sort of cleric." He asks why she's present, given her family's feelings, and sympathizes that he, as a Thayan, is also often misapprehended by those around him. Lirael makes her way to Hermiphony to apologize for any perceived slight and tell her that she had sensed that Terrian might have been interested in the economic potential of "her" railway. Hermiphony sees the sincerity in the apology and relents on her position. She confides in Lirael that Terrian's association with the Zhentarim is worrying, and that they might try and steal the technology and take over the development from Thar. Lennox, sensing the mood lightening, comes over to the pair to ask more about the smelting and development of the magical steel. She tells him that the secret to Ironclaw steel is a special ore they found beneath Xul'jarak, which has as a vein of some kind of unusual material. He makes a passing remark about not revealing that information to anyone who wasn't part of the conversation, or who has been to the temple. She becomes very interested in that, asking if he has been to Xul'jarak, and he becomes evasive and tongue-tied. She is suspicious, but leaves it be for the moment.

Harken passes by Terrian and tells him, he hopes he's enjoying his discussion with the Baron, to which the merchant agrees. Taevyn rather nervously tries to flatter Kia and tries to find out what she knows about the Iron Fist. She notes that he calls them "freedom fighters" rather than "terrorists" or a "genocidal cult." He claims to try to reserve judgement. She begins rhetorically interrogating him, trying to figure why he might be sympathetic to anti-orcish sentiment. He learns that Uriah's wife and son were killed, marching against the orcs.

Beitris asks Doran Ma if he's a member of House Moje. Anger flashes briefly across his features, and he excuses himself quickly, leaving the party. Lirael asks Hermiphony why Lord Silverweave is present, and if she'd considered the potential of her steel in tandem with his TrueSilk™. She says that he was there almost solely because they were trying to make a match for Kia Kiulaudra. Lirael suggests that perhaps Taevyn might help him make up his mind. She turns back to Lennox, continuing her line of questioning about Xul'jarak. He

manages to tell her something approximating the truth, and her gaze snaps back to Lirael as she whispers, "the chosen one!"

Lirael, meanwhile, moves to Taevyn to warn him about Tomag's reputation and interest. He is dismissive of any threat the man might pose and thinks he's not Kia's type. She tells him to be careful, regardless. Harken moves to Tomag and tells him that Taevyn will mess it all up, and he doesn't need to lower himself to compete with the young man. Tomag is dismissive and uninterested in Harken's input. He starts striding toward Taevyn, who is dancing by himself on the floor, still trying to make eyes at Kia. She is getting more uncomfortable by the minute.

Beitris goes to Baron Ironclaw to apologize for Doran Ma's departure, mortified that whatever she said caused him to depart. He's moved by her words, and brings out a jeweled box, containing a card from War for the Crown. He offers her one of the special copies, representing The Zhent. Beitris is completely caught off guard, and thanks the Baron effusively. He mentions that he overheard her conversation with Ma, and notes that Laronen's reputation as one of the most murderous mages in recent memory might have been what set the man off.

Lirael moves to intercept Tomag before he approaches Taevyn and suggests that approaching Kia might work better to his advantage than engaging Taevyn. She attempts to use her magic to amplify the suggestion, and while he doesn't succumb to the spell, the logic of her position is clear to him, and he stalks off to the food with minor notes of gratitude. Lennox continues to talk to Clemeth about diet and exercise. She tells him that drinking water in equal quantity to beer helps mitigate the worst of the impact. Harken moves to Hermiphony, thanking her for her hospitality, and complimenting the food and company. The Baroness excitedly calls Clemeth over, telling Harken that she's convinced that the party might well have been "chosen" to be the ones to help them with the railroad project. She invites them all back to tea the next day to discuss the possibilities.

As the night draws to a close, Taevyn approaches Kia Kiulaudra, telling her all the dancing helps him think. He tells her that he thinks she agrees that they've made a connection, and that they're staying at the Cock and Bull. He asks if she might be free the next day to meet up for a meal. She tells him her schedule is quite busy but suggests he's welcome to join her and her friends at the gladiatorial games next week. He happily responds, "oh, great! It's a date then!"

Moonsea Rising -20240629

The Ironride's Maiden Voyage

While Lennox is off getting his tattoos, Lirael talks to Hermiphony and Clementh, who introduces her the engineer, Glimmerknock Steamwhistle, asking about why the Ironride is such a target for bandits. He explains that specially treated and ensorcelled gems power the Ironride without depletion, potentially for millennia. While expensive to produce, and highly valuable over the lifetime of the train, they will cost much less over the years. There are a dozen in the engine, and one smaller one in each trailing car. Lirael asks what happens if the cars' gems are interfered with. Glimmerknock tells her the cars drag would start to accumulate and could potentially still the train itself.

Taevyn tags along with Lennox to the tattoo parlour, pumping the man for dating advice for his imagined courtship of Kia Kilaudra. Harken has Lirael stow his skull on the train so he can subtly explore the train and see how it works.

Beitris, with the Baroness' help, pens an apology letter to Doran Ma. She also studies the game book more, finding that while it's dedicated towards building the Empire in the best possible way, all the actions seem to be centred around the founding, such that all actions taken then determine the outcome of the game. It seems heavily biased in favour of their original reality, though she, like Lirael, doesn't think this version is so bad. She scours the rulebook, looking for hints about optimizing outcomes in the real world, while theorizing that the games are representative of a real power struggle among powerful individuals.

She and Taevyn are both worried about possibly facing Nikolai and Uriah. Beitris takes a hard line that these aren't people they know, just temporal doppelgängers of people they left behind. She counsels striking if need be.

As the party joins Harken on the Ironride, he fills them in on the layout of the train, containing:

- locomotive
- luggage car
- 2x passenger cars
- luxury berths
- dining car
- kitchen car
- caboose

He tells them that the cars have a pull-cord for distress signalling to the engine, as well as a fully staffed orcish crew, in the event of non-emergency messaging.

As the party positions themselves throughout the train (Lirael in the locomotive, Lennox in luggage, Beitris in the luxury car looking for plants, Harken back in dining, and Taevyn with his crossbow in the caboose), the Ironride prepares to depart. Taevyn eyes the ladders to the roof with interest, a far-away look in his eyes.

They settle down for the six-hour trip to Thar and the Ironride sets out. The first couple of hours are uneventful, but late in the third hour, Lirael's ears pick up the sound of horses

along the track to the south. Looking out of the engine, she sees several horsemen with red face paint and bows approaching. Lennox also notices, as they nock arrows and aim towards him.

Lennox bolts to his feet, roaring a challenge, as they begin loosing arrows. They rain down around the big man as he ponders returning the attack. Back in the lap of luxury, Beitris continues sipping a sparkling orcish beverage, listening to the drummer in the corner, completely missing the man's yell.

Lennox drops flat against the train roof, until someone comes in range of him. Another archer fires, hitting him in the thigh, though the angle makes doing worse damage difficult. In the kitchen, Harken is trying to telekinetically filch small morsels he cannot enjoy. Lennox continues taking fire, the train car helping him significantly, though not protecting him completely. From the engine Lirael slings a ray of frost at the lead rider, striking him, and quickly taking cover in the engine again.

As the riders start to lose ground to the train, the archers continue to fire at Lennox, but the train's speed works to his advantage here. Glancing briefly to her left, Beitris notices a group of five horsemen clearly firing arrows at someone further up the train. She steps out onto the joiner platform between the cars firing her crossbow and ducking around the corner. Lennox reconsiders axe usage, and swings down into the luggage car, grabbing his bow and getting ready to return fire. The bowmen fire at Beitris, their arrows clattering off the corner of the train car.

Harken's incorporeal ears twitch, as he notices the frightened screams of passengers further up the train. He moves forward, trying to locate the source of the danger. A couple of the archers manages to tag Beitris with arrows, as the Ironride rolls one.

In the caboose, Taevyn scans the western horizon, and manages to catch sight of the bowmen to his southeast. Taevyn grabs the roof, flipping up on top of the train and sprints towards the engine, rolling off his leap between the cars, and covering two cars in a matter of seconds. Lirael fires another ray of frost and begins awkwardly moving back along the train as the horsemen continue lagging.

The horsemen, now alongside Beitris, fire a series of arrows at her, hitting her again. Moving into the carriage, she ducks down behind the walls. Invoking Lathander, she heals some of her wounds. Bow in hand, Lennox runs back out of the luggage car, heaving himself up onto the roof, and continuing towards the caboose. He immediately takes arrow fire, another one striking him.

Harken focuses, gesturing at the path. Limestone spikes erupt under the horsemen. With horrible screams, several of the horse pitch directly in the spikes, writhing and kicking, trapping their riders, and bleeding from scores of lacerations. Only two of the riders manage to avoid the horror-show Harken has summoned. One of them manages to hit Lennox with another arrow, as Taevyn continues to race along the train top. Rolling through one of his jumps, he catches a glimpse of a figure climbing onto the roof of the caboose. Spinning, he fires his crossbow at the unknown figure. A bolt, rimed with frost magic, strikes the newcomer, who tumbles off the roof and out of sight. Taevyn shouts about attackers from the south.

At the far end, Lirael hears none of that. Swaying with the train, she makes her way back towards the first passenger car. The two remaining horsemen fire their bows on Taevyn as the motion of the Ironride brings him closer. Beitris looks at the lagging horsemen, as they fall further behind.

Nikolai Steele. The man is doing a good job of feigning fear, and quickly pulls his hood back into place. Looking back at Lirael, she points directly at Nikolai Steele. Shouldering her crossbow, she fires a bolt at him, missing.

Lennox races down the roof, leaping to the second passenger car, and shoots an arrow that hits the lead rider square in the chest. The man rocks in his saddle but stays upright. Harken, hearing Taevyn's warning, turns invisible and heads towards the back of the train. A couple more arrows strike Taevyn. At the back, the robed female Taevyn shot pulls herself back onto the roof. She slings an acid arrow at Taevyn, striking him and covering him in corrosive goop. Taevyn returns fire with his crossbow, hitting her twice. He backs up along the train.

Lirael continues forward, slinging a ray of frost at Nikolai, but the motion of the train knocks her askew. He turns to rush Beitris, who shifts her crossbow out of the way, and motions him to come on, watching him carefully for any kind of reaction. At the last second, instead of running her through, he slaps the crossbow out of her hands with his sword, scowling in confusion.

As the horsemen begin to fall out of range, the only target they can see is Taevyn, and two more arrows hit him.

In the second passenger car, Beitris attempts to throw her arms around Nikolai and kiss him. He is intensely confused, especially as she calls him by name. She attempts to use their code phrase, but he doesn't recognize it, and is looking around for other hostiles, assuming this is a distraction. He tells her, "You seem to have me at a disadvantage; you know me, but I don't know you."

Lennox, completely unaware of what's happening below him, continues advancing to Taevyn's position, firing on the caster who attacked him. He fires again, striking her heavily with an arrow.

Harken climbs up on a table and pokes his head through the roof. He casts a phantasmal killer at the woman, who is wracked with the illusory damage. The horsemen fire at Taevyn, hitting him with one arrow, and causing his shark-tooth tattoo to flare up shattering the second shot. Taevyn's eye's flash briefly black as he glares at the rider.

The mage fires a lightning bolt at Taevyn, who dances aside, chuckling. He grabs a healing potion from his belt, quaffing it in a gulp, and firing the crossbow at the mage. The bolt catches her in the throat, frost ringing the wound as she tumbles limply off the back of the train. His second shot hits the man who shot him, grievously wounding him.

Lirael continues moving towards Beitris and Nikolai, stopping between the cars and hiding around the corner.

Nikolai raises his sword to attempt to knock Beitris out. Frowning, she moves to one side, and his successive strikes are even less successful. She says, "if you wanted to dance, Nikolai, you could have just asked me." He continues to be confused and upset, potentially unaware of how badly his raid is going. He points out that he doesn't know her, and she's in league with the orcs of the Iron-ride. She tells him, as a priest of Lathander, she can force herself to only speak the truth. He looks at her, considers, and says "do it."

She casts a zone of truth and tells him she must speak truth. He asks her if she's in league with Ironclaw, and she admits that she'd met him just recently. He asks if she's protecting the Ironride, and she likewise admits it's true. He asks how she knows who he is, and she tells him, "In another timeline, you and I had a very different relationship." He is very confused.

Running out of foes, Lennox moves to the gap between the luxury and dining cars and drops down to train level. He continues forward, calling to the others for status. Glancing down, Lirael notices someone down below, trying to decouple the link between the passenger cars.

Harken continues to move to the back of the train, entering the kitchen car. He immediately notices all three orcish cooks lie dead on the ground, and a woman in black with red face paint stands over them. She appears to be putting something into one of the ovens. He reaches out, and black energy crackles around her, rippling into his invisible plasm. She whirls around, looking for her attacker. Taevyn continues to the back of the train, dropping down between the cars, and tumbling into the kitchen. He pops up with rapier drawn.

Lirael spreads her hands, concentrating, and pets swarm out of the air, whirling and biting him. Channelling the latent energy from the spell into her spear, she flings it at the man, hitting him. He grunts at the pain but remains focused on his task.

Meanwhile, in the kitchen, the black-clad woman decides Taevyn is her assailant. Quickly envenoming her weapon, she stabs him with it.

Nikolai asks Beitris, "what do you mean a different timeline? Are you from the future?" She tells him she's from an alternate time when there was a Moonsea Empire, and Nikolai was a Baron. He is incredulous, tells her she's mad. She asks him why he's so against the train. He believes it's an evil orc plot, and a magical disaster waiting to happen. The lightning and fire gems could destroy massive areas when, not if, control over them is lost. As he turns to leave, she raises one hand and touches his face. He looks towards where Lirael and the man working the coupling are but turns back.

Lennox comes up behind Beitris and sees this tender moment. Having his bow in his hand, he fires an arrow, hitting Beitris in the shoulder. She dived between Lennox's arrow and Nikolai.

Harken summons the phantasmal killer in the kitchen again, harrying the woman as she struggles with Taevyn. She flinches but keeps her eyes on the younger man. Taevyn slashes with his rapier, striking her with a flourish that opens a long wound. He follows up attempting to disarm her, but she keeps her grip.

Back with the whip man working the coupling, Lirael focuses, and her forms morphs and swells into a massive gorilla. Ripping and tearing at the man, she attempts to fling them both from the train, though he manages to hang on out of pure shock.

Moonsea Rising -20240727

In the caboose, the dark-haired assassin looks at Taevyn and says, "what did you say?" He tells her he expected Uriah --his father --back here. She tells him Uriah's son died years ago. She asks him his sister's name, if he is who he says he is. He tells her Uriah didn't have a daughter. The assassin, Clarissa Vellen, tells him she is Uriah's only living child, and his fraud is poorly crafted. He is shocked, but tells her it's complicated, and exhorts her to stop this, no one else needs to die. She pauses and treats her wounds with a powder from her pack. She keeps her weapon trained on Taevyn, however, and tells him that she'll take him to Uriah, and they'll see what's what.

Nikolai deftly plucks the arrow from Beitris' arm, stuffing a small cloth from his pack into the gash. Looking at her, he asks her why they're trying to kill everyone, telling her the train is set to explode when it reaches Tgorsk. Horror fills her face, and she lurches toward Lirael, trying to warn her. Lennox, behind her, leaps to the train top, and races across the car towards the engine.

Uriah finishes his decouple, and sidles back into the car, away from Lirael. Eyeing her cautiously, he says to Beitris, "so, you're not Zhentarim?" She looks at him incredulously. "I'm wearing the full regalia of a cleric of Lathander. I am not Zhentarim." She claims her name, and he scoffs, as he knows this timeline's Beitris Marsk, and she is not the other. Beitris unloads on him, using the full brunt of her vocabulary, to tell him that she knows who she is. Uriah turns to Nikolai in confusion, asking the other man what is going on. With the zone of truth bonging and clanging along with the priestess' words, the men stare at her.

Taevyn attempts some fancy footwork, but stumbles and falls. Raising to his feet, and trying to look like nothing happened, he and Clarissa take off towards the engine, with Harken telekinetically and invisibly dragging his skull-bag behind him. Looking at the parley happening in the passenger car, Lirael swings onto the roof and knuckles quickly towards the engine. Behind her, Lennox hurdles the gap, closing with her.

In the car, Uriah asks Beitris who she works for. The assailants tell her that Ironclaw was manipulated into backing this project, which is a Zhent plot to create war between Thar and Mel-vaunt. Uriah tells her he's seen visions of the apocalypse, of the grand war that's coming to the Moonsea. He draws a card from his armour, bearing the sigil of the Temple of Xul'Jarak. However, the image is clearly from before it was lost, showing the gates inside the gaping maw of a roaring orc. Uriah repeats to her that he's seen the end and knows what happens. Beitris brandishes The Dagger, and tells him they're on the same side, and she's seen the visions.

At that, Taevyn and Clarissa burst into the car. He looks around, drawing up short when he sees Uriah. After identifying the man, he tells him, "It's me, papa. It's Taevyn, your son." He tells Beitris this is a cruel trick, and that the son that would have been Taevyn died in an orc raid. She tells him in her timeline, he is the one who died in that raid. The man slumps to a seat on one of the train benches. Taevyn approaches him and tells him, "I never got a chance to meet my father." Uriah tells him Taevyn was eaten by the orcs in his infancy. The orcs on the train all look... uncomfortable, adjusting their modern finery and muttering about barbarism. Taevyn tells him he'd like to get to know the man he never knew. Uriah stares at him for a second and tells him he has his mother's eyes. Beitris looks pointedly at the zone of truth surrounding them as Taevyn, eyes streaming, embraces Uriah.

One of the orcs stands up and says, "well, isn't this touching?" Placing her hand lightly on Uriah's chest, the man flies backwards out the window and off the train. Clarissa yells, "no!" She dives out the window after him, as Taevyn and Beitris immediately move to the attack.

Harken arrives just as the orc shimmers and transforms into an auburn-haired human female, in full Lathandrite armour. Lady Beitris Marsk frees her weapon and straightens up. Harken arrives, takes in the conflict, and smacks Dark Beitris with his telekinetic hand, attempting to create a diversion. Taevyn, rapier in hand, dives out of the moving train car after Uriah, and Nikolai comes up behind him, pressing the attack. He says, "Tris, you bitch, you're not going to get away with this."

She blocks his arm as he swings and knocks the sword from his hand. She tells him, "Nikolai, you were always so soft. I can't believe I ever had feelings for you." Moving her hand and speaking in guttural tones, a cone of shadowy lightning fills the train car. The passengers are fried where they stand, as Nikolai, Harken, and Beitris are all wracked with dark magics. Beitris attempts to tackle her through the window and out of the train. The other woman isn't expecting it, and both tumble out through the window. Tris rolls her shoulder, and lands on top of Beitris, rolling off and coming quickly to her feet. Beitris rolls, fling a vial of holy water which explodes in a burst of magic. Tris spins, catching most of the blast on armour.

Clarissa, meanwhile, has made it to Uriah, and appears to be checking his injuries. Harken summons a phantasmal killer tearing at her mind. Lirael drops into the engine, returning to her normal form, and enters the engine. She finds it empty, no sign of the gnome or the engineer. She and Lennox quickly examine the control scheme, and she finds the magic rod that controls the train appears to have been removed.

Taevyn quaffs a potion, looks at Clarissa, and tells her he needs to help his friends. He races towards Beitris and Tris. Nikolai, still on the train, tries to check the orc civilians, and starts herding those in good enough shape towards the back.

Snarling, and mistaking the caster, Tris fires killer phantasms back at Beitris, scoring the woman's psyche. "Tough. I won't miss you." She sprints towards the train, looking to leap back on. Groaning, Beitris rises to her feet, summoning Lathander's Grace to ease her wounds.

Clarissa leaps at the passing end of the caboose, barely making it back on the train. Harken watches all this wryly. He messages Nikolai, telling him Tris is attempting to get back on the train. Nikolai asks him who it is, but Harken stands mute.

In the engine, Lirael summons the powers of the mage card, and figures out that, absent the control rod, she'd need to start removing the gems from the outside of the engine, which are protect-ed by a force field. However, she thinks that she could potentially derail the train, if she could do enough damage to the tracks. She moves to the door to the engine and tells Lennox, "Get every-one off the train!" He looks at her, and grabs his axe, moving towards the back.

Taevyn nimbly leaps onto the nearest car and strikes a parry pose, waiting for Tris to try and re-board. She leaps onto to the VIP car and disappears inside. Beitris jumps up beside Taevyn, healing his wounds as Clarissa races past towards the car with Tris and Harken. He steps into the hallway, as Tris is racing forward. As she passes, he extends his hand into her head, attempting to drain her life force. He's rebuffed, as she barrels on, barely noticing his attempt. Taevyn enters the back of the VIP car just as she passes him, taking cover behind the back wall. Nikolai enters from the other end.

Tris whirls around, sensing Harken's malign intent. Identifying his likely location, she rips a phantasmal killer at him, but the shade is unaffected. Beitris continues advancing behind her fleeter colleagues.

From between the engine and luggage cars, Lirael shoots into the air, landing it a fiery blast 60' ahead of the train. The tracks are blasted and twisted beyond recognition, and she quickly moves directly away from the tracks, hoping to avoid the impending derailment.

Completely unaware of the coming disaster, Clarissa catches up with Taevyn, firing her crossbow at Tris and missing. Taevyn stabs at her, his weapon scoring a line across her armour, but otherwise ineffectual. As he dances around her, Nikolai presses his attack as well, but the Marsk woman stands her ground. Uriah leaps onto the train as well.

As Tris is about to strike Taevyn she looks up, alarmed. A portal opens, and she steps through it, disappearing. Beitris follows Taevyn, catching up with him in the VIP car.

As the train hits the damaged track, a lot of things happen very quickly. The uncoupled cars spill of the tracks, clacking and bouncing off one another, rolling across the countryside. Those in the cars are tossed about, though most of Lirael's friends manage to brace for impact, getting knocked about, but managing to survive Faerun's first train derailment.

The engine, miracle of miracles, remains upright, ploughing up the turf and squalling to an inglorious stop some hundreds of feet from Lirael. She braces for a blast that never comes, opening her eye after several seconds in pure wonder. She looks at the giant iron beast, steaming slightly in the grass. As the groans start arising from the smashed cars, she turns, and walks back to where her friends are, hopefully, alive.

["The Wreck of the Iron Ride"](#)

Moonsea Rising -20240810

The Harkening

Beitris -- Rose Red -- offers Harken the final choice. He can be released, or he can depart. Harken turns invisible, but Rose's eye's glow a bright red, following the spectre. He messages her, asking her continued mercy for his condition. Her face hardens, but her resolve is clear. He ducks through the wreckage, trying to keep it between himself and the priestess, now of the god of duty -- and vengeance. Resignedly, he messages her that he will leave. Under her breath she says, "another time, then. I will see you at rest." Using his powers, he winks his skull out of the wreckage and begins dragging it off into the countryside.

Taevyn and Lennox both notice the cast of her shoulders and approach her. She tells them Harken as fled, referring to him as "it," lest she destroy it. The other men accept this with concern, but both trust the priestess. Taevyn seems a little upset with the conflict, but Rose hugs him, and he accepts. Lennox wraps his arms around them.

Banging erupts from the wrecked dining car. Lirael approaches, checking for the elemental core. It's present, but the banging is coming from its position in the car. Lennox and Taevyn enter the car, finding a banging noise coming from one of the meat coolers. A young man in leathers rolls out of the cooler, bounding to his feet.

He looks at Lennox and tells him, "Whomever you are, don't go drinking with halflings. Aren't you a little big for a halfling?" He managed to completely miss the wreck, sleeping off his drunk in the cooler. Taevyn introduces himself, and the man -- Maximillian Handy -- introduces himself as a "bard extraordinaire!" The man vomits extravagantly against the side of the overturned train car, protesting his perfect health all the while.

Nikolai comes over and tells them he hasn't found any sign of Glimmerknock in the crash, which is completely out of character for the gnomish madman. Baron Ironclaw agrees with this, and discussions of Tris' involvement with the Zhentarim. Maximillian seems to be completely unaware that her was even on the Ironride and mentions that he heard someone talking about packages and someone named "Virgil," during brief moments of lucidity.

Lirael is concerned about the elemental cores, and consulting with Clementh and Hermiphony thinks the major cores can remain in the engine until salvage arrives, and the smaller cores can be more easily collected. Ironclaw says they need to find Glimmerknock if they hope to get the Iron-ride running again. Lirael points out that Glimmerknock might well be a puppet of the Zhentarim, which makes recovering him even more important.

Taevyn offers to backtrack the train to look for where Glimmerknock was taken, and the others join him, of course. Max asks to tag along, seeing the seeds of an epic story in the offing. Before they leave, Rose goes to Nikolai, casting a spell of status on him, kissing the man before they part. Clarissa seems shocked by this display, quickly turning sour and walking off. Max nudges Lennox and asks him if he knows who Uriah and Nikolai are. Lennox says he does, and Max drops it. He instead asks if he has any drink and takes it gratefully when offered.

Gnomolocation

The party moves down the track, looking for signs of Glimmerknock's exfiltration. There is precious little to find, until Rose and Lennox both notice a tree with upside-down branches

and a nearby patch of trampled ground. Checking the tree, they find a blind intended to cover the course of a path into the forest.

Exploring with some caution, they find a clearing with steps carved into the rock face, leading up. Stopping by the edge of the trees, Taevyn cautiously creeps up to, and up, the steps, peering carefully over the top. Two women in green and brownish robes are hiding in bushes on the next flat level up. Moving carefully, Taevyn moves back down and returns to the others, describing what he's seen.

It doesn't sound like a Zhent trap, but caution is truly warranted. Rose suggests she and Lirael approach, cautiously, and attempt to parley in case they are peaceful. Max offers to come with them, and he and Rose debate the relative merits, while Lirael is looking around for signs and sigils. All signs point to a druid circle, and that they'll be unable to approach stealthily. Lirael opts to call out to them in fey that they have come in peace and are simply looking for something. They tell them to approach with weapons sheathed and hands up.

They do, and the head druidess asks why they've intruded on the Shadowbark Druids' circle. Lirael asks if they've seen anyone with a struggling gnome come through their lands, and she denies it. Rose notices furtive glances to left and right and thinks something might be amiss. She quietly responds, "not true. Watch the plinths." Lirael peers ahead and sees shadows. Her spirit-sense detects people behind each of the three stones. She tells the druidess in fey, "we will leave, but if the people behind the stones are a problem, send us a signal." She tells the others, "We should go." They follow her lead, and within seconds a bird lands on a tree near them. In fey, it speaks, saying, "Zhentarim. Help."

Lirael tells them the bird has indicated Zhents and she detected three people, one behind each stone. She suggests that they find a different approach, and they quietly circle the rise, finding an unguarded approach from the back. Max offers to form a magical staircase, which he quickly does. Taevyn crouches, climbing the steps and peering over the top. Seven Zhents, all facing the stairs on the other side. Taevyn becomes invisible, creeping up to the nearest one and preparing a strike. Max renders Lennox invisible as well, and the man tries to follow, but steps on a branch, just over the top lip. The nearest Zhents turn, weapons drawn, peering into the forest.

Max snaps another branch, off to the side, hoping to turn the Zhents in the wrong direction, which they do. Lennox steps up to his target, viciously swinging his axe and catching the man fully off-guard. Two strikes leave the man bleeding and at death's door, as the other Zhents turn towards him. The man nearest Taevyn moves away from Lennox, firing two poorly aimed bowshots at him. A fusillade of arrows rains down around the big man, several striking him various blows.

Lirael rockets into the air, crashing to the ground behind two of the Zhents, spraying them with rock and fire. Air bursts from around her, knocking the nearest man off the ledge, and he grunts as he falls to the ground. Taevyn tumbles past the man Lennox was killing and stabs him with his rapier. His follow-up misses, and the Zhent continues to draw breath. He draws a potion from his belt, but Lennox swings his axe, dispatching the man before he can drink it.

Almost as one woman, the druids begin a chant. The stones begin to hum with magical power. Lirael recognizes a water spell about to shoot from the stones. Max bounds up, playing a rousing song on his mandolin. Lennox charges the man by Lirael, hitting him with his axe. Lennox kicks him off the ledge, and he falls, hitting the Zhent trying to climb back up.

Rose steps up next to Taevyn, glaring down one of the Zhents. The man looks shaken, as the Zhents unleash a volley of arrows at the angry priestess.

Lirael tells them to get away from the stones, and casts, turning into a massive unicorn. She moves to the centre of the camp, trying to get some cover from the tents. Taevyn rushes the shaken Zhent, cutting the man deeply, leaving him bleeding, and sweeping up into a parry.

Water explodes inward from the plinths in massive cones, hitting Lirael, Rose, Glimmerknock, and one of the Zhents. Lirael rears, the jet missing her, as Rose rolls to one side. Glimmerknock and the Zhent are blasted aside, shifting across the camp. Max strums a usual tune, and several small crowds appear throughout the camp, cheering him on and confusing everyone else.

Lennox continues rushing about like a bull in a china shop, striking the nearest Zhent with his axe. Rose moves to the nearest tent, healing herself. The Zhents try to switch to melee but are rather less dangerous in that way. The Liraelicorn leaps over the tent, spearing the nearest Zhent with her horn. Taevyn calls to Rose, flaunting the ease with which he finds fighting the Zhents, and skewers the bleeding man next to him again. Turning from the bleeding man, he slashes at the other man, opening another gaping wound.

The druids cast a series of entangling spells, capturing the wounded and nearly dead Zhents in their vines. Two of the Zhents are still alive when the party gets to interrogation, though the two who fell off the cliff had managed to escape.

["Let Harken Go"](#)

Moonsea Rising - 20240825

Saviors of the Shadowbark

The party gathers around the injured Zhent. As Taevyn and Rose attempt to treat his wounds, Lirael unleashes her blood magic. The Zhent, Ivan, falls immediately under her spell, becoming unfailingly helpful. His companion tries to hush him, but Taevyn and Lennox drag him away at her signal.

Lirael questions Ivan, who tells her, willingly, that Tris has likely taken the control rod to the temple of Norgorber in Melvaunt. He describes the precise way to locate the temple, as Lirael's skin crawls. Rose wants to know if the Marsk are entangled with the Zhents. Ivan tells them that they are deeply enmeshed, and Tris reports to "The Druid," the second or third placed person in the Zhentarim. Lirael asks his name, and, while he won't speak it, he writes Aemon's name in the dust. Lirael vaguely remembers stories her grandmother told her of a druid who turned to Norgorber and was subsequently killed, of the same name.

Ivan counsels against going to the temple, lest they be killed. Lirael tells him she hopes it won't come to that. As they wrap up their conversation, he asks for safe passage. She tells him he owes a debt to the Shadowbark Circle, but she will ask, not tell, them that they allow the men to atone if they are able.

The lead druidess is unfavourably disposed to this, but Lirael tells her it is her decision, once they leave. She explains that her involvement with the Ironride is a result of a long and twisted road, and for the greater good of the region and Faerun, as she understands it. The druidess has no words for this and turns away.

The talk to Glimmerknock, who tells them that destroying the rod will cause the gems to detonate. He suggests they get the gems as rapidly as possible. The druids become distressed on hearing the train might still explode and ask how they can help. The party needs transport, as well as warning the other survivors. The druids arrange giant eagles to bring them back to Melvaunt and send several crows to warn Nikolai and the others.

Rose issues a quick message to Nikolai to clear the crash site, keep an eye on Uriah for any changes wrought by his card, and where they're going. She's about to tell them to meet in Melvaunt when Maximillian reminds her that they've probably got a date with the hangman if they're spotted in the city. She accedes and leaves the message as is.

Hot Times, Summer in the City

Lennox suggests they contact the Silver Swords, and Rose agrees, since killing the Zhentarim is their raison d'etre. Max looks at them like they're crazy and has never heard of the Silver Swords of Jessica Talianos. Lirael sighs. While reinforcements would be nice, creating a riot isn't exactly the outcome she wants. Any of the orders, if they believed their reports, wouldn't keep quiet about rooting out a temple of Norgorber.

They loiter in the promenade for a while, observing the temple building surreptitiously. Only Rose spots a clerk wearing a very specific kind of boot more common in sneak thieves than clerks. Rose casts locate object, which shows it about 40' beneath the house in question. While they start thinking about sneaking through a multi-level subterranean temple, Lirael offers that she should well be able to burrow through from an adjacent basement. As they digest this information, and go back to looking at the street, Taevyn wants to sneak in the

rear entrance the special clerks have been entering. Lirael is incredulous and sceptical that this might succeed, and Max suggests if they just want to see the inside, he's got the thing.

Striding across the street, he snaps his fingers and a lively tune swells up around him. He strides confidently into the main entrance, pitching a show he's doing and trying to drum up attention. As he marks his surrounding, and the clerk does his best to shoo him out, he notes what seems to be a perfectly normal insurance office. Many major concerns, houses we all know and love, are evident on various bits of paper and labels on folders. Allowing himself to eventually be shown out, he returns to the others, telling them what he's seen.

While they start trying to figure out how to convince someone to let them dig up their basement, Lirael further suggests they'll want some cover of night, and the miner's guild next door isn't likely to be open all night. The others see the wisdom of this, and Taevyn slides off to acquire some picks for the night's work.

You son of a bitch. I'm in!

Taevyn easily opens the miner's guild, and the others pile quietly in. At Lirael's suggestion, Max casts telepathic bond from one of the scrolls they had found. Heading to the basement, they gather in the corner closest to the location of the rod. Lirael shifts into an earth elemental, and begins burrowing at a downward angle, before they reach a wall. Lirael asks the others if they should just break through, or if they have better ideas. No one does, so she pushes through the elderly stone, and they land in six inches of water. From the next room over they hear chanting and see flickering lights.

Taevyn pokes his head around the corner and looks in on the dark sanctuary. Four glowing orbs of light hang around the pedestal in the middle of the central mosaic. Tris stands next to a robbed figure, clearly in the middle of a ritual. Along the walls of the room, a dozen or more other hooded figures stand chanting along. Lirael says she can rush them in air form and flee with the rod, if they're ok fighting a rear-guard action. Rose and Lennox believe the ritual has less than a minute remaining, so they bless her plan.

Shifting into elemental form, she flies into the room, coming to a stop at an invisible barrier. It seems to run between the three orbs, and, thinking quickly, she blasts it with a massive gust. The orb dissolves, and she tells the others that they control the field, as the three remaining orbs shift into a triangle to maintain the cover. Taevyn levels the dark sun signet ring and casts a blast of force at one of the other orbs, which rocks but remains. Max mutters something, and a parade of a dozen people forms in the room behind him. Strutting like a peacock, he leads his parade into the room, to the astonished view of the ritual participants.

Lennox charges the orb, smashing it with his axe. As it disappears, the acolytes in the nearest corner scream as they are consumed by black flame. Another orb springs into existence where it stood. He swings the axe again, and the horrifying spectacle repeats itself, as he stares down the acolytes in the remaining corners. Rose draws her hand-and-a-half sword, advancing on the nearest orb. She swings the blade twice, dispatching another orb, and another group of acolytes fuel its replacement.

The Zhents are slow to respond, but Tris casts a spell Lirael recognizes as a ward. She warns the others, and calls, telepathically, for them to get the orbs down. She waits, biding her time to grab the rods. Taevyn moves up, making his habitual flourishes as he swings at the nearest orb. He stabs it, but it remains.

Max, deprived of an audience, sends his parade towards the centre of the room. As it collides with the barrier, he sings an encouraging tune. Lennox raises his axe to strike the

orb in front of him, but Tris' spell stays his hand. Growling, he charges the remaining group of acolytes, swinging his axe. He carves into the nearest one with a ferocious swing.

Rose swings the sword again, dispatching one of orbs and killing the rest of the acolytes. She swings again, bringing down the orb. The orbs shift again, cutting the room in half, with the party opposite the rod. Lirael makes a frustrated susurration, flying to the corner and gusting the penultimate orb apart. The final orb swoops to the middle of the room, settling over the rod.

Tris looks angry that her ritual is being interrupted. Continuing the chant, she looks at Lennox and begins to assault his mind. He looks at her and says, "bullshit, fake Beitris." The spell fizzles, and Tris puts a hand to her temple as the magics unwind and cause some backlash. Her remaining priest casts a volley of magic missiles at Beitris, which catches them on her shield. Taevyn steps forward stabbing the orb with his rapier and dissipating it. The hooded priest looks slightly worried as he strikes a parry pose before the two Zhents.

Max points at the rod, trying to lift it magically. A wave of force flows back along the threads, knocking him back. He begins hurling insults at Tris, who is starting to get nervous about the whole thing. Lennox, still in the corner, charges around Rose and Taevyn, lowering his shoulder and slamming into the plinth on which rod rests. He bounces off, but swings his axe at Tris, who dodges. He catches her with the return swing, clanging off her armour.

Rose raises her hands, flinging a phial of holy water which explodes in a massive burst, smashing into the Zhents. She abjures her dark doppelgänger, threatening her with Ragathiel's vengeance. Tris looks even more fearful, as Lirael zips forward, reaching for the artifact. Some kind of barrier saps her will, and she slaps at it with her gust, but is unable to dislodge it.

Tris grits her teeth, casting dark magics at Lirael, who resists the worst of the effect, but is shaken. Her priest continues casting as well. Taevyn tumbles behind her, stabbing with his rapier. Max fires a prismatic ray, which just misses Tris, and he hollers and catcalls her, trying to keep her off balance. Lennox tries to grab the rod again, but Tris' magic prevents him. Angry, he hits Tris twice with his axe, the dark priestess looking much the worse for the wear. Rose tries to grab the rod, but Tris' magic prevents her. She summons Ragathiel's guidance on Lirael. Fighting against the magic, Lirael manages to seize the rod. In an instant, the magic breaks, flinging the hooded priest backward, and Lirael, still a zephyr, flies out of the room, back up their impromptu tunnel, and out of the story.

Tris screams in rage as Lirael disappears, an explosion of black energy filling the room, the void energies flaying the remaining party members, but bolstering the hooded priest. He crawls up off the floor, pulling a greataxe from his robes, and running to intercept Taevyn. He stabs at Tris, but misses, badly, and his lungs immediately fill with seawater. Coughing and gagging, he raises his blade to parry.

Max casts a spell, pronouncing doom on Tris, and denotes Rose's blade as the instrument of her destruction. Tris flinches, the spell amplifying his words, as she eyes the bastard sword into the other woman's hands. Lennox steps up, swinging his axe repeatedly.

Rose steps forward, Max's magic thrumming in the air. She swings the bastard sword, slamming into Tris, and calls down Ragathiel's vengeance through her blade. The occult and divine magics surge along the length of the blade, grounding in Tris who screams as the sword cuts into her.